



BIG 12 PREVIEW



PREDICTED ORDER OF FINISH

	1	TEXAS TECH RED RAIDERS
	2	BYU COUGARS
	3	HOUSTON COUGARS
	4	UTAH UTES
	5	KANSAS STATE WILDCATS
	6	ARIZONA WILDCATS
	7	ARIZONA STATE SUN DEVILS
	8	OKLAHOMA STATE COWBOYS
	9	TCU HORNED FROGS
	10	WEST VIRGINIA MOUNTAINEERS
	11	KANSAS JAYHAWKS
	12	BAYLOR BEARS
	13	CINCINNATI BEARCATS
	14	COLORADO BUFFALOES
	15	UCF KNIGHTS
	16	IOWA STATE CYCLONES

BIG 12 CHAMPIONSHIP TEXAS TECH OVER BYU



JOIN COLLEGE FOOTBALL EXPERT STEVEN LASSAN AT ATHLONSports.com FOR A LOOK AT SECOND- AND THIRD-TEAM SELECTIONS

ALL-BIG 12 TEAM

FIRST-TEAM OFFENSE

QB	NOAH FIFITA	Arizona
RB	LJ MARTIN	BYU
RB	CAM COOK	West Virginia
AP	CALEB HAWKINS	Oklahoma State
WR	AMARE THOMAS	Houston
WR	OMARION MILLER	Arizona State
WR	WYATT YOUNG	Oklahoma State
TE	TERRANCE CARTER JR.	Texas Tech
C	BRUCE MITCHELL	BYU
OL	JOE COTTON	Cincinnati
OL	EVAN TENGESDAHL	Cincinnati
OL	JOHN PASTORE	Kansas State
OL	SHADRE HURST	Houston

FIRST-TEAM DEFENSE

DL	A.J. HOLMES JR.	Texas Tech
DL	MATEEN IBIROGBA	Texas Tech
DL	WENDELL GREGORY	Kansas State
DL	ADAM TRICK	Texas Tech
LB	AUSTIN ROMAINE	Texas Tech
LB	TAYE BROWN	Arizona
LB	CADE ULUAWE	BYU
LB	BEN ROBERTS	Texas Tech
CB	BRICE POLLOCK	Texas Tech
CB	WILL JAMES	Houston
S	JAMEL JOHNSON	TCU
S	FALETAU SATUALA	BYU

FIRST-TEAM SPECIALISTS

K	STONE HARRINGTON	Texas Tech
P	PALMER WILLIAMS	Baylor
KR	BRYCE NOERNBERG	Kansas State
PR	MANA CARVALHO	Utah

BOWL PROJECTIONS

Rate: TCU vs. Illinois

Pop-Tarts: Houston vs. Louisville

Texas: Oklahoma State vs. Missouri

Independence: West Virginia vs. Kennesaw State

Alamo: BYU vs. USC

Sun: Utah vs. Virginia

Las Vegas: Arizona vs. Iowa

Armed Forces: Arizona State vs. Navy

Liberty: Kansas State vs. Auburn

College Football Playoff First Round: Texas Tech vs. Oregon

COORDINATOR CAROUSEL

BAYLOR

Defense: New: Joe Klanderman
Old: Matt Powledge

BYU

Defense: New: Kelly Poppinga
Old: Jay Hill

CINCINNATI

Offense: New: Nic Cardwell, Pete Thomas; Old: Brad Glenn
Defense: New: Nate Woody, Cortney Braswell; Old: Tyson Veidt, Cortney Braswell

COLORADO

Offense: New: Brennan Marion
Old: Brett Bartolone (interim)
Defense: New: Chris Marve
Old: Robert Livingston

IOWA STATE

Offense: New: Tyler Roehl
Old: Taylor Mouser
Defense: New: Jesse Bobbit
Old: Jon Heacock

KANSAS

Offense: New: Andy Kotelnicki
Old: Jim Zebrowski, Matt Lubick

KANSAS STATE

Offense: New: Sean Gleeson
Old: Matt Wells
Defense: New: Jordan Peterson
Old: Joe Klanderman

OKLAHOMA STATE

Offense: New: Sean Brophy
Old: Doug Meacham
Defense: New: Skyler Cassity
Old: Clint Bowen (interim)

TCU

Offense: New: Gordon Sammis, A.J. Ricker; Old: Kendal Briles

TEXAS TECH

Defense: New: Shiel Wood, Rob Greene; Old: Shiel Wood

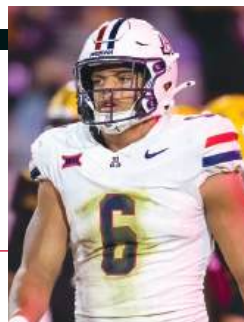
UTAH

Offense: New: Kevin McGiven
Old: Jason Beck
Defense: New: Colton Swan
Old: Morgan Scalley

TOP 10 RECRUITS

NAME	POS.	SCHOOL	RATING	NAT. RANK
1. Keisean Henderson	QB	Houston	★★★★★	4
2. Kelvin Obot	OT	Utah	★★★★★	5
3. Kevin Brown	IOL	West Virginia	★★★★	49
4. LaDamion Guyton	EDGE	Texas Tech	★★★★	58
5. Ryder Lyons	QB	BYU	★★★★	60

TAYE BROWN, ARIZONA
DREW MESTEMAKER,
OKLAHOMA STATE



TOP TRANSFERS

NAME	POS.	SCHOOL	FORMER SCHOOL
1. Drew Mestemaker	QB	Oklahoma State	North Texas Mestemaker led the nation with more than 4,000 passing yards.
2. Caleb Hawkins	RB	Oklahoma State	North Texas Hawkins is a touchdown machine who followed his QB to the Big 12.
3. Cam Cook	RB	West Virginia	Jacksonville State All-American who led the country in rushing will run wild for Rich Rodriguez.
4. Brendan Sorsby	QB	Texas Tech	Cincinnati Sorsby's talent made him a coveted addition, but his availability is an open question.
5. Mateen Ibirogba	DL	Texas Tech	Wake Forest Ibirogba is a twitchy big body who should help Tech's defense reload.
6. DJ Lagway	QB	Baylor	Florida After battling injuries, the former 5-star prospect gets a fresh start in his home state.
7. Danny Scudero	WR	Colorado	San José State A ball magnet who led the FBS in receiving yards for the Spartans.
8. Omarion Miller	WR	Arizona State	Colorado Miller is following in Jordyn Tyson's footsteps; he'll hope to have the same success.
9. Adam Trick	DL	Texas Tech	Miami (Ohio) Trick is a proven disruptor off the edge for the Red Raiders' defense.
10. Jaden Craig	QB	TCU	Harvard The Crimson's all-time leading passer fills the void that Josh Hoover left.

RECRUITING RANKINGS BY SCHOOL

1. Texas Tech (19)	6. Kansas State (41)	11. TCU (50)
2. West Virginia (27)	7. Arizona State (42)	12. Kansas (60)
3. BYU (30)	8. Arizona (44)	13. UCF (61)
4. Houston (32)	9. Iowa State (45)	14. Oklahoma State (63)
5. Utah (35)	10. Cincinnati (47)	15. Baylor (66)
		16. Colorado (73)

Rankings per Rivals; National ranking in parentheses

GAMES TO WATCH

Sept. 12 Arizona at BYU

Sept. 19 Houston at Texas Tech

Oct. 10 Houston at Kansas State

Oct. 17 Notre Dame at BYU

Oct. 17 Arizona State at Texas Tech

Oct. 17 TCU at Baylor

Oct. 24 Kansas State at Arizona State

Oct. 24 Houston at Utah

Nov. 7 BYU at Utah

Nov. 14 Texas Tech at Oklahoma State

Nov. 14 Utah at Arizona

Nov. 28 Arizona State at Arizona

NAME	POS.	SCHOOL	RATING	NAT. RANK
6. Chase Campbell	WR	Texas Tech	★★★★	63
7. Jake Fette	QB	Arizona State	★★★★	86
8. RJ Mosley	WR	Arizona	★★★★	92
9. Malachi Joyner	IOL	Arizona	★★★★	119
10. Felix Ojo	OT	Texas Tech	★★★★	142

Rankings per Rivals; +Consensus 5-star prospect



ARIZONA WILDCATS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 32 | BIG 12 PREDICTION: 6 | 2025 RECORD: 9-4, 6-3 BIG 12

OFFENSE Arizona's offense returns the reigning first-team All-Big 12 quarterback in Noah Fifita, who became the first UA quarterback to receive first-team all-conference honors in 50 years. Fifita needs 829 yards to pass Nick Foles for the most career passing yards by an Arizona quarterback. Fifita already broke Foles' career passing touchdowns record last season and will likely go down as the statistical leader in every passing category at the UA when it's all said and done.

For the first time since becoming the starter, Fifita will have the same offensive coordinator as the previous season. Another year with rising play-caller Seth Doege could take Fifita — and the Arizona offense — to another gear. Arizona also returns a nucleus of wide receivers in Tre Spivey, veteran Chris Hunter and Giovanni Richardson, among others.

DEFENSE Defensive coordinator Danny Gonzales signed a contract extension this offseason and was named a Broyles Award semifinalist for the best assistant coach in college football. In the unit's first season under Gonzales, Arizona finished seventh nationally in passing defense and helped the team post a plus-18 turnover margin. The Wildcats had more takeaways (31) than touchdowns allowed (28) and led the Big 12 in interceptions (22), which tied for second nationally. They led college football in takeaways per game (2.4).

Arizona will have to replace a good chunk of the production, especially in the secondary following the loss of defensive backs Treydan Stukes, Genesis Smith and Dalton Johnson, who combined for 6,700 defensive snaps in their Arizona careers. The Wildcats signed eight defensive backs in the transfer portal in 2026, but replacing the heartbeat of Arizona's defensive secondary will be a tall task this fall.

SPECIALISTS Arizona placekicker Michael Salgado-Medina finished 19-for-31 on field-goal attempts in 2025, the most misses in a season for the UA since 1999, although snapping inconsistencies were a factor. Salgado-Medina was 5-for-12 between 40-49 yards but displayed leg strength with a 57-yarder against Oklahoma State, and he was more consistent throughout the spring. The Wildcats will have several new faces in the special teams unit, including Australian punter Chase Ridley, who will likely be the starter for the season opener against FCS Northern Arizona.

FINAL ANALYSIS Continuity is an underrated component to college football. Arizona has it for 2026. The Wildcats return all of their coordinators and most of their on-field staff. More importantly, the face of the franchise in Fifita returns for another season to put an exclamation point on his storied career at the UA.

2025 RESULTS (9-4, 6-3 BIG 12)	2026 SCHEDULE	TOP 10 RECRUITS*
Aug. 30 Hawai'i W 40-6	Sept. 5 Northern Arizona	1. R.J. Mosley, WR ★★★★★
Sept. 6 Weber State W 48-3	Sept. 12 at BYU	2. Malachi Joyner, IOL ★★★★★
Sept. 12 Kansas State W 23-17	Sept. 19 Northern Illinois	3. Justin Morales, IOL ★★★★★
Sept. 27 at Iowa State L 14-39	Sept. 26 at Washington St.	4. Henry Gabalis, TE ★★★★★
Oct. 4 Oklahoma State W 41-13	Oct. 3 Cincinnati	5. Oscar Rios, QB ★★★
Oct. 11 BYU (ot) L 27-33	Oct. 10 at West Virginia	6. Xaier Hiler, CB ★★★
Oct. 18 at Houston L 28-31	Oct. 24 Iowa State	7. Keytrin Harris, DL ★★★
Nov. 1 at Colorado W 52-17	Oct. 31 at Texas Tech	8. Kevin Moorer, EDGE ★★★
Nov. 8 Kansas W 24-20	Nov. 7 TCU	9. Harvie Moeai, EDGE ★★★
Nov. 15 at Cincinnati W 30-24	Nov. 14 Utah	10. Caleb Smith, WR ★★★
Nov. 22 Baylor W 41-17	Nov. 21 at Kansas State	
Nov. 28 at Arizona State W 23-7	Nov. 28 Arizona State	
Jan. 2 vs. SMU # L 19-24		
#Holiday Bowl		

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Brent Brennan • Record at School: 13-12 (2 years)
Career Record: 47-60 (9 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Seth Doege
Defensive Coordinator: Danny Gonzales • Location: Tucson, Ariz.
Stadium: Casino Del Sol Stadium (50,782)



NOAH FIFITA

SCOUTING THE WILDCATS

"[QB Noah Fifita] is freaking electric. He's one of the best quarterbacks in the country. His off-schedule playmaking ability is unbelievable. When he gets flushed out of the pocket, the play begins. I thought their wideouts were really good. Obviously, they didn't have a guy that was like [former Arizona wide receiver] Tetairoa McMillan, but they were pretty deep, and it felt like every other week, it was a different guy making plays. ... On defense, they're so different with [defensive coordinator] Danny Gonzales. No one in the league really plays like them. They're innovative up front, and they like to play a lot of man coverage on the back end. They had some corners and DBs who could win in man coverage, and any time you can do that, that's a recipe for success."

— An opposing Big 12 assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (4)

WR	12	TRE SPIVEY (JR.)	4	DJ Jordan* (So.)
WR	11	Chris Hunter (Sr.)	10	Jordan Ross* (Jr.)
WR	5	Giovanni Richardson (So.)	84	Rodney Gallagher III* (Sr.)
LT	73	Matthew Lado (So.)	66	Jaxon Griffin (Fr.)
LG	59	Rhino Tapa'atoutai (Jr.)	77	Jake Griffin* (Jr.)
C	58	Zach Henning* (Jr.)	62	Javian Goo (Fr.)
RG	63	ALEXANDER DOOST (JR.)	79	Isaac Perez (Sr.)
RT	71	TRISTAN BOUNDS (SR.)	72	Louis Akpa (Fr.)
TE	14	Cole Rusk* (Sr.)	87	Tyler Powell (Sr.)
QB	1	NOAH FIFITA (SR.)	7	Sawyer Anderson (Fr.)
RB	3	Kedrick Reescano (Sr.)	24	Quincy Craig (Sr.)

DEFENSE (4)

DE	3	TRE SMITH (SR.)	42	Dominic Lolesio (Jr.)
DT	95	LEROY PALU (SR.)	96	Zac Siulepa (Jr.)
DT	99	Mays Pese (So.)	44	Prince Williams (Fr.)
LB	7	CHASE KENNEDY (SR.)	48	Cooper Blomstrom* (Sr.)
LB	6	TAYE BROWN (SR.)	11	Jabari Mann (So.)
LB	16	Everett Roussaw Jr.* (Sr.)	10	Myron Robinson (So.)
CB	8	Jay'Vion Cole (Sr.)	12	Dwight Bootle* (Jr.)
CB	9	Tyrese Boss* (So.)	25	Zuri Watson* (So.)
NB	15	Malcolm Hartzog* (Sr.)	20	Dajon Hinton (Fr.)
S	23	Gavin Hunter (Jr.)	13	Cam Chapa* (Jr.)
S	2	Daylen Austin* (Jr.)	17	Lee Molette III* (Sr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	19	Michael Salgado-Medina (Jr.)	KR	84	Rodney Gallagher III* (Sr.)
P	37	Chase Ridley (Fr.)	PR	84	Rodney Gallagher III* (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



ADRIAN WILSON

SCOUTING THE SUN DEVILS

"I've been impressed with who they picked up in the portal. The question is, how do those pieces in the portal come together? They're a tough, physical team, and in the Big 12, it's more finesse offenses. ... They're better across the board; they're better at wideout. I know they had Jordyn Tyson, but he was kind of in and out of the lineup. [Colorado transfer receiver] Omarion Miller is a special player, [Boston College transfer receiver] Reed Harris is a special player, and they have some young guys that they like. ... I think they'll be better on both sides of the line of scrimmage, just with the way they've been recruiting. They'll lose a bit of production in the backfield because I thought Raleek Brown was really, really good. But I'm expecting them to be good."

— An opposing Big 12 assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (O)

WR	4	Omarion Miller* (Sr.)	18	Jalen Moss (Sr.)
WR	3	Reed Harris* (Jr.)	16	Jaren Hamilton (Jr.)
WR	7	Raiden Vines-Bright* (So.)	5	Derek Eusebio (Jr.)
LT	76	Champ Westbrooks (So.)	75	Jarmaine Mitchell* (Jr.)
LG	64	Wade Helton (So.)	74	Siosaia Lapuaho* (Jr.)
C	58	Tana Alo-Tupuola* (Jr.)	64	Wade Helton (So.)
RG	59	Maki Stewart (So.)	53	Rob Lapuaho (Fr.)
RT	78	Luke Baklenko* (Sr.)	70	Jalen Klemm (Sr.)
TE	15	Khamari Anderson (Sr.)	85	Anthony Miller* (Jr.)
QB	8	Cutter Boley* (So.)	2	Jake Fette (Fr.)
RB	1	Kyson Brown (Jr.)	28	Marquis Gillis* (Sr.)

DEFENSE (2)

DE	9	Jalen Thompson* (Sr.)	98	Julian Hugo (Fr.)
DT	99	C.J. FITE (JR.)	97	Blazen Lono-Wong (Jr.)
DT	93	MyKeil Gardner (So.)	92	Zac Swanson (Jr.)
DE	10	Clayton Smith (Sr.)	32	Emar'ion Winston* (Sr.)
ILB	22	Owen Long* (Jr.)	49	Prayer Young-Blackgoat (So.)
ILB	8	Martell Hughes (Jr.)	30	Zyrus Fiaseu (Sr.)
CB	1	Ashton Stamps* (Jr.)	16	Nigel Pringle* (Fr.)
CB	0	Rodney Bimage Jr. (So.)	19	Daquwan Dunn (Fr.)
NB	6	ADRIAN WILSON (JR.)	12	Ben Alefaio-Lilili (Fr.)
SS	7	Montana Warren (Jr.)	20	Maurice Williams (Jr.)
FS	5	Lyrik Rawls* (Sr.)	23	Jessiah McGrew* (So.)

SPECIALISTS

K	38	Carson Smith* (Sr.)	KR	16	Jaren Hamilton (Jr.)
P	35	Nick McLarty* (So.)	PR	84	Cory Butler Jr. (Fr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



ARIZONA STATE SUN DEVILS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 35 | BIG 12 PREDICTION: 7 | 2025 RECORD: 8-5, 6-3 BIG 12

OFFENSE The Sun Devils will lean heavily on the No. 15 transfer portal class (per 247Sports) to overcome the departures of most of their starters to graduation or transfer, including quarterback Sam Leavitt's move to LSU. Cutter Boley, who started for Kentucky as a redshirt freshman, will likely be the triggerman of an offense that added the nation's top-ranked wide receiver transfer class, headlined by Omarion Miller (Colorado) and Reed Harris (Boston College) and one that also includes Raiden Vines-Bright (Washington). All three look like future NFL Draft picks.

Center Tana Alo-Tupuola, who helped Georgia Tech rank as one of the top rushing attacks in the FBS last season, will help stabilize an offensive line that also added transfer Luke Baklenko — a former starter at Stanford who played at Oklahoma last season — at right tackle.

ASU's backfield is deep and talented, with 2025 opening-game starter Kyson Brown back at full strength after a season-ending injury and newcomer Marquis Gillis, who rushed for more than 1,100 yards at FCS Delaware State last season, a potent addition.

DEFENSE ASU should again be very stout, led by all-conference candidate C.J. Fite at nose tackle and transfer ends Jalen Thompson (Michigan State) and Emar'ion Winston (Baylor). Owen Long, the FBS' leading tackler last season at Colorado State, will help replace second-team All-Big 12 linebackers Jordan Crook and Keyshaun Elliott, with sixth-year returner Zyrus Fiaseu and Martell Hughes also starter-level players.

The secondary could be ASU's biggest question, especially the all-important nickel position, where Adrian "Boogie" Wilson could start in a move from free safety. Ashton Stamps, a two-year starter at LSU, will help replace Keith Abney II and Javan Robinson at cornerback, with sophomore Rodney Bimage Jr. ready to shine. Senior free safety Lyrik Rawls was a key addition after leading Kansas with 57 solo tackles last season.

SPECIALISTS Big-legged Australian punter Nick McLarty, an Ohio State transfer, should help ASU improve from second-worst in the FBS in net punting in '25. Austin Peay transfer placekicker Carson Smith earned Specialist of the Year honors in the FCS United Athletic Conference.

FINAL ANALYSIS Although they look deeper and more talented than head coach Kenny Dillingham's prior three teams, the Sun Devils will need to prove that they didn't regress too much at quarterback with their move from Leavitt to Boley. The Sun Devils are likely to be pegged to finish in the middle of the Big 12, but they look better than that. A brutal schedule won't help them show it in the win column, though.

2025 RESULTS (8-5, 6-3 BIG 12)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 30	Northern Arizona	W	38-19	Sept. 5	Morgan State	1. Jake Fette, QB	★★★★
Sept. 6	at Mississippi State	L	20-24	Sept. 12	at Texas A&M	2. Cardae Mack, RB	★★★★
Sept. 13	Texas State	W	34-15	Sept. 19	vs. Kansas #	3. Hayden Vercher, TE	★★★★
Sept. 20	at Baylor	W	27-24	Oct. 3	Baylor	4. Landen Anderson, DL	★★★★
Sept. 26	TCU	W	27-24	Oct. 10	Hawai'i	5. Julian Hugo, EDGE	★★★★
Oct. 11	at Utah	L	10-42	Oct. 17	at Texas Tech	6. Jarmaine Mitchell, OT	★★★★
Oct. 18	Texas Tech	W	26-22	Oct. 24	Kansas State	7. Davis Kinney, S	★★★★
Oct. 25	Houston	L	16-24	Oct. 31	at BYU	8. Cortavius Tisaby, OT	★★★★
Nov. 1	at Iowa State	W	24-19	Nov. 7	Colorado	9. Landen Miree, TE	★★★★
Nov. 15	West Virginia	W	25-23	Nov. 14	at UCF	10. Zeth Thues, S	★★★★
Nov. 22	at Colorado	W	42-17	Nov. 21	Oklahoma State		
Nov. 28	Arizona	L	7-23	Nov. 28	at Arizona		
Dec. 31	vs. Duke #	L	39-42		#London, England		*Per Rivals
			#Sun Bowl				
TEAM INFORMATION							
Head Coach: Kenny Dillingham • Record at School: 22-17 (3 years)							
Career Record: 22-17 (3 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Marcus Arroyo							
Defensive Coordinator: Brian Ward • Location: Tempe, Ariz.							
Stadium: Mountain America Stadium (53,599)							



BAYLOR BEARS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 62 | BIG 12 PREDICTION: 12 | 2025 RECORD: 5-7, 3-6 BIG 12

OFFENSE Quarterback DJ Lagway holds the keys to the Baylor offense this season. The former 5-star prospect comes to Baylor — where his dad was a running back 25 years ago — after two up-and-down years at Florida. “Every day I wake up, it’s a blessing, because I’m living six-year-old me’s dream,” Lagway says.

Lagway is one of many new faces expected to fill a lot of holes on offense, as the Bears replace their top four receivers, tight end, running back, quarterback and four of five starters on the offensive line.

After redshirting last season, wide receiver Louis Brown IV is expected to play a key role on the outside, while Jadon Porter is back for his third season in Waco and hopes to have a larger role. Dre’lon Miller did a little bit of everything at Colorado and will have a similarly large role at Baylor.

Dawson Pendergrass will lead the backfield after missing last season with a foot injury, but he has three promising underclassmen behind him.

DEFENSE After two years of calling plays on defense, head coach Dave Aranda has handed those duties to first-year defensive coordinator Joe Klanderman, who spent the past six seasons at Kansas State. Klanderman’s scheme is predicated on creating havoc and getting pressure on the quarterback, something Baylor struggled with mightily last season. “One of the things we’re talking about now is havoc rate,” Klanderman says. “We’re trying to create that by letting those defensive linemen rumble. We’re more of an attacking style than we are a reacting style.”

The Bears focused on adding pressure-inducing game-wreckers in the front seven, including Hosea Wheeler from Indiana, Jamaal Whyce Jr. from Marshall, Ryan Davis from Kansas State, Garrick Ponder from Southern Miss and Kedrick Walker from Georgia State.

Cornerback LeVar Thornton Jr. had a strong season last year and returns to anchor the back end, while Devin Turner, a former All-Big Ten safety at Northwestern, returns after missing last year with a torn ACL.

SPECIALISTS Palmer Williams was a finalist for the Ray Guy award after averaging 46.9 yards per punt. The Bears are replacing their starting kicker, Connor Hawkins, who was a late exit via the transfer portal, with sophomore Rhett Armstrong, who was highly rated coming out of high school and handled kickoff duties last year, although he hasn’t attempted a field goal in a game. The return spots remain an open competition.

FINAL ANALYSIS This is a do-or-die season for Aranda. The school decided to bring him back for a seventh season just to keep things stable when former athletic director Mack Rhoades left in a lurch near the end of last year. There is no magic number that will save his job, but Aranda knows that the pressure is on to win, and win now.

2025 RESULTS (5-7, 3-6 BIG 12)			2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 29	Auburn	L 24-38	Sept. 5	vs. Auburn #	1. Ryelan Morris, RB	★★★★
Sept. 6	at SMU (ot)	W 48-45	Sept. 12	Prairie View A&M	2. Quinn Murphy, QB	★★★★
Sept. 13	Samford	W 42-7	Sept. 19	Louisiana Tech	3. Jae’Lin Battle, DL	★★★★
Sept. 20	Arizona State	L 24-27	Sept. 26	Colorado	4. London Smith, WR	★★★★
Sept. 27	at Oklahoma State	W 45-27	Oct. 3	at Arizona State	5. HD Davis, RB	★★★★
Oct. 4	Kansas State	W 35-34	Oct. 17	TCU	6. Donel Robinson Jr., IOL	★★★★
Oct. 18	at TCU	L 36-42	Oct. 24	at Kansas	7. Davion Peters, WR	★★★★
Oct. 25	at Cincinnati	L 20-41	Oct. 31	at UCF	8. Jamarion Richardson, CB	★★★★
Nov. 1	UCF	W 30-3	Nov. 7	Iowa State	9. Jordan Davis, S	★★★★
Nov. 15	Utah	L 28-55	Nov. 14	at BYU	10. Kai Wesley, TE	★★★★
Nov. 22	at Arizona	L 17-41	Nov. 21	Texas Tech		
Nov. 29	Houston	L 24-31	Nov. 28	at Houston		
			#Atlanta		*Per Rivals	

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Dave Aranda • Record at School: 36-37 (6 years) • Career Record: 36-37 (6 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Jake Spavital • Defensive Coordinator: Joe Klanderman • Location: Waco, Texas • Stadium: McLane Stadium (45,140)



LEVAR THORNTON JR.

SCOUTING THE BEARS

“There are times on film when that defense looks phenomenal. Certain games last year, they’d look great on film, and then there were certain games when they couldn’t stop the run. Against Utah, they were giving up 80-yard runs like it was a cup of water. That’s gonna be their challenge. It’s the consistency. Right now, they’re lacking consistency. ... I think [head coach] Dave Aranda is the real deal. Scheme-wise, he’s phenomenal. But he’s just a little weird. Maybe a little socially awkward. But he knows football. ... Maybe he should just be calling plays the whole time. They go through a lot of coaches on defense, too. When you go through a lot of coaches on your staff, that’s a sign.”

— An opposing Big 12 assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (1)

WR	24	Louis Brown IV (Sr.)	88	Taz Williams Jr. (Fr.)
WR	11	Dre’lon Miller* (Jr.)	82	London Smith (Fr.)
WR	83	Jadon Porter (Jr.)	16	Gavin Freeman* (Sr.)
LT	77	Logan Moore* (Jr.)	75	Harrison Cluff (Fr.)
LG	70	Nate Kibble* (So.)	78	Cole Rhett* (Jr.)
C	68	Yakiri Walker* (Sr.)	66	Koltin Sieracki (So.)
RG	66	Koltin Sieracki (So.)	71	Matthew Parker (Fr.)
RT	74	KADEN SIERACKI (SR.)	72	Asher Hale* (Jr.)
TE	85	Matthew Klopfenstein (Sr.)	81	Tony Livingston* (Sr.)
QB	12	DJ Lagway* (Jr.)	14	Nate Bennett (So.)
RB	35	Dawson Pendergrass (Jr.)	22	Caden Knighten (So.)

DEFENSE (4)

DE	99	Jamaal Whyce Jr.* (Sr.)	53	Daemian Wimberly* (Jr.)
DT	91	Hosea Wheeler* (Sr.)	98	Jackson Blackwell (Fr.)
DT	59	DEVONTE TEZINO (SR.)	97	Jordan Mack* (Sr.)
DE	40	Kyler Jordan (Sr.)	93	Zavion Hardy* (Sr.)
ILB	36	Travion Barnes (Sr.)	50	Kedrick Walker* (Sr.)
ILB	41	Kaleb Burns (So.)	45	KYLAND REED (JR.)
JACK	52	Ryan Davis* (Jr.)	51	Garrick Ponder* (Sr.)
CB	25	LEVAR THORNTON JR. (JR.)	23	Stilton McKelvey* (Jr.)
CB	18	Devon Jordan* (Jr.)	22	Reggie Bush II (Sr.)
S	13	Devin Turner (Sr.)	24	Micah Gifford (Sr.)
S	28	JACOB REDDING (JR.)	15	Colby McCalister* (Sr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	98	Rhett Armstrong (So.)	KR	16	Gavin Freeman* (Sr.)
P	94	Palmer Williams (Sr.)	PR	16	Gavin Freeman* (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



BEAR BACHMEIER

SCOUTING THE COUGARS

"They're the best team in our conference. They're the most physical team. They have the best coaches, and they have great energy. They play complementary football — offense, defense, special teams. At the line of scrimmage, they look totally different than any other Big 12 team. I think that program is about to skyrocket. ... This is the year that they'll get over the top. If they don't this year, I don't know that they ever will. The reason I say that is because of the influx of money they got with their roster. ... Year 2 with [QB] Bear Bachmeier, Year 4 with LJ Martin, who is one of the best backs in the country, you return a lot of guys on defense that were really productive. [Faletau Satuala] was one of the best — if not the best — safeties we played all year."

— An opposing Big 12 assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (4)

WR	13	Jojo Phillips (Jr.)	0	Tei Nacua (So.)
WR	3	Kyler Kasper* (Jr.)	18	Reggie Frischknecht (So.)
WR	5	Cody Hagen (Jr.)	19	Tiger Bachmeier (Sr.)
LT	58	Paki Finau* (So.)	52	Bott Mulitalo (Fr.)
LG	51	Sonny Makasini (Sr.)	56	Zak Yamauchi* (So.)
C	63	BRUCE MITCHELL (SR.)	67	Trevor Pay (So.)
RG	64	Kyle Sfarcioc (Sr.)	74	Trevin Ostler (Sr.)
RT	75	ANDREW GENTRY (SR.)	62	Jr Sia* (Jr.)
TE	7	Walker Lyons* (Jr.)	2	Roger Saleapaga II* (Jr.)
QB	47	BEAR BACHMEIER (SO.)	10	Treyson Bourguet (Sr.)
RB	4	LJ MARTIN (SR.)	30	Sione Moa (So.)

DEFENSE (7)

DE	48	BODIE SCHOONOVER (SR.)	45	Viliami Po'uha (Jr.)
NT	96	Justin Kirkland (Sr.)	99	Ulavai Fetuli (Fr.)
DT	57	KEANU TANUVASA (SR.)	94	Anisi Purcell (Sr.)
DE	5	Nusi Taumoepeau (So.)	13	Tausili Akana (Jr.)
OLB	4	Cade Uluave* (Sr.)	33	Maika Kaufusi (Jr.)
MLB	54	SIALE ESERA (JR.)	18	Ace Kaufusi (Jr.)
OLB	16	ISAIAH GLASKER (SR.)	31	Jake Clifton* (Jr.)
CB	0	EVAN JOHNSON (SR.)	26	Jordyn Criss (Fr.)
CB	1	THERRIAN ALEXANDER III (JR.)	15	Jayven Williams* (Sr.)
SS	10	FALETAU SATUALA (JR.)	17	Jarinn Kalama (So.)
FS	3	Raider Damuni (Sr.)	22	Tommy Prassas (So.)

SPECIALISTS

K	97	Matthias Dunn (Sr.)	KR	5	Cody Hagen (Jr.)
P	19	Fuller Shurtz (Fr.)	PR	32	Cannon DeVries (So.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



BYU COUGARS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 16 | BIG 12 PREDICTION: 2 | 2025 RECORD: 12-2, 8-1 BIG 12

OFFENSE The Bear is back. Quarterback Bear Bachmeier flourished as a freshman in 2025 after not even arriving on campus until June. After participating in spring drills at Stanford last year, Bachmeier stunned everyone by beating out two seasoned backups and then led the Cougars to the Big 12 Championship Game, where they lost to Texas Tech for the second time in a month. Bachmeier started in all 14 games for the 12-2 Cougars, completing 65% of his passes for 3,033 yards and 15 touchdowns, with only seven interceptions. Even bigger things are expected of the Southern California native in 2026.

Another notable returnee is running back LJ Martin, the 2025 Big 12 Offensive Player of the Year. The senior ran for 1,305 yards last year and can become one of the most prolific running backs in school history — top three, at least — with another big year.

DEFENSE Utah head coach Kyle Whittingham's departure for Michigan left a dent at rival BYU as well, as three-year Cougars defensive coordinator Jay Hill followed his former coach to Ann Arbor. Hill's defense in his third season at BYU was among the Big 12's best — allowing just 332.4 yards and 19.1 points per game. Head coach Kalani Sitake decided on special teams coordinator Kelly Poppinga to fill that role, and Poppinga has a fairly full cupboard to work with.

Utah transfer Keanu Tanuvasa will be the heart of the front seven, aided by former Cal linebacker Cade Uluave, a gem from the transfer portal. Junior safety Faletau Satuala will help the new secondary coaches get settled in, but there are question marks, especially with defensive passing game guru Jernaro Gilford joining Hill and Whittingham at Michigan.

SPECIALISTS Gone are kicker Will Ferrin, punter Sam Vander Haar and long-snapper Garrison Grimes. Senior kicker Matthias Dunn has been in the program for several years and will finally get his chance to shine — at least until former five-star recruit Brody Laga returns from a church mission. When Vander Haar didn't get a waiver for another season, BYU turned to freshman Fuller Shurtz in spring camp, and the results so far have been mostly positive.

FINAL ANALYSIS BYU just missed out on the College Football Playoff each of the past two seasons, going 11-2 in 2024 and 12-2 in '25. So expectations are soaring in Provo for Sitake in his 11th season, especially after the school broke the bank to keep the coach from going to Penn State last December. BYU won't be sneaking up on anybody this year, but the Cougars should have enough firepower and enough defense to contend for another berth in the Big 12 Championship Game.

2025 RESULTS (12-2, 8-1 BIG 12)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 30	Portland State	W	69-0	Sept. 5	Utah Tech	1. Ryder Lyons, QB	★★★★
Sept. 6	Stanford	W	27-3	Sept. 12	Arizona	2. Brock Harris, TE	★★★★
Sept. 20	at East Carolina	W	34-13	Sept. 19	at Colorado State	3. Bott Mulitalo, IOL	★★★★
Sept. 27	at Colorado	W	24-21	Oct. 3	at TCU	4. Ty Goettsche, TE	★★★★
Oct. 3	West Virginia	W	38-24	Oct. 10	Iowa State	5. Lopeti Moala, DL	★★★★
Oct. 11	at Arizona (ot)	W	33-27	Oct. 17	Notre Dame	6. Adam Bywater, LB	★★★★
Oct. 18	Utah	W	24-21	Oct. 24	at UCF	7. Jaron Pula, WR	★★★
Oct. 25	at Iowa State	W	41-27	Oct. 31	Arizona State	8. Jax Tanner, IOL	★★★
Nov. 8	at Texas Tech	L	7-29	Nov. 7	at Utah	9. Legend Glasker, WR	★★★
Nov. 15	TCU	W	44-13	Nov. 14	Baylor	10. Graham Livingston, WR	★★★
Nov. 22	at Cincinnati	W	26-14	Nov. 21	at Kansas		
Nov. 29	UCF	W	41-21	Nov. 28	Cincinnati		
Dec. 6	vs. Texas Tech #	L	7-34				
Dec. 27	vs. Georgia Tech %	W	25-21				
#Arlington, TX %Pop-Tarts Bowl				TEAM INFORMATION Head Coach: Kalani Sitake • Record at School: 84-45 (10 years) Career Record: 84-45 (10 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Aaron Roderick Defensive Coordinator: Kelly Poppinga • Location: Provo, Utah Stadium: LaVell Edwards Stadium (62,073)			



CINCINNATI BEARCATS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 63 | BIG 12 PREDICTION: 13 | 2025 RECORD: 7-6, 5-4 BIG 12

OFFENSE Cincinnati is replacing virtually every skill player from last season, starting with quarterback Brendan Sorsby, who committed to Texas Tech via the portal as one of the highest-paid players in the country. To replace him, the Bearcats landed on Georgia Southern's JC French IV.

The wide receiver room has to be rebuilt to a large extent. Isaiah Johnson will have a big role thanks to his lightning speed. Additions like JV Gibson, Lorenzo Fenner, and Cade Wolford fill out the rest of the room.

The Bearcats boast a great offensive line that returns three starters — All-American Evan Tengesdahl, Taran Tyo and sought-after left tackle Joe Cotton. Expect the offense to lean heavily on the ground game with running backs Zion Johnson, Gi'Bran Payne and Zylan Perry, and then use the play-action pass, an approach that French is familiar with.

DEFENSE First-year defensive coordinator Nate Woody is implementing a pressure-based 3-3-5 scheme, but as with the offense, the Bearcats are replacing some studs from the 2025 season. Jake Golday and Dontay Corleone will both play in the NFL, while defensive backs Christian Harrison and Jiquan Sanks both transferred after the season.

Cincinnati added support at defensive tackle in Josh Hough and Chidera Otutu, while solidifying the defensive backfield with safety Ty Goodwill and cornerback Kenny Worthy. Defensive end Marquaze Parker has been consistent since his true freshman season and projects to play a massive role as the Bearcats' best pass-rusher opposite outside linebackers Brian Simms III and Thomas Johnson. Northern Illinois transfer Filip Maciorowski will play the Golday role as a high-volume tackler capable of getting after the quarterback.

Expect the scheme and heightened investment on the defensive side of the ball to lead to much more chaos, with a big uptick in forced turnovers.

SPECIALISTS Cincinnati is returning placekicker Stephen Rusnak and punter Max Fletcher, both of whom had great first seasons as starters and should take another step forward. Isaiah Johnson makes the most sense as the kickoff and punt returner — he's the team's fastest and shiftest player.

FINAL ANALYSIS It will be hard for Cincinnati to have a better season in 2026 than it did in 2025, simply because of all the departed talent. French should be the deciding factor. While he isn't as explosive as Sorsby, Cincinnati should have a better running game to make French's job easier. The defense played well enough last season to keep UC in games, but the turnover numbers were not where they needed to be. The new scheme should help with that in 2026.

2025 RESULTS (7-6, 5-4 BIG 12)	2026 SCHEDULE	TOP 10 RECRUITS*
Aug. 28 vs. Nebraska # L 17-20	Sept. 5 Boston College	1. Lance Dawson, DL ★★★★★
Sept. 6 Bowling Green W 34-20	Sept. 12 Western Carolina	2. Jalen Williams, TE ★★★
Sept. 13 Northwestern State W 70-0	Sept. 19 Miami (Ohio) #	3. Austin Hoane, IOL ★★★
Sept. 27 at Kansas W 37-34	Sept. 26 Kansas State	4. Luke Collins, IOL ★★★
Oct. 4 Iowa State W 38-30	Oct. 3 at Arizona	5. Jaidon Windom, S ★★★
Oct. 11 UCF W 20-11	Oct. 17 at West Virginia	6. Solomon Mathis, OT ★★★
Oct. 18 at Oklahoma State W 49-17	Oct. 24 Texas Tech	7. Markell Taylor, S ★★★
Oct. 25 Baylor W 41-20	Oct. 31 Utah	8. Jonathan Rulo, DL ★★★
Nov. 1 at Utah L 14-45	Nov. 7 at Houston	9. Joshua Smith, ATH ★★★
Nov. 15 Arizona L 24-30	Nov. 14 at Iowa State	10. Jaxon Newton, LB ★★★
Nov. 22 BYU L 14-26	Nov. 21 Colorado	
Nov. 29 at TCU L 23-45	Nov. 28 at BYU	
Jan. 2 vs. Navy % L 13-35		

#Kansas City, MO %Liberty Bowl

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Scott Satterfield - Record at School: 15-22 (3 years)
Career Record: 91-70 (13 years) - Offensive Coordinators: Nic Cardwell, Pete Thomas - Defensive Coordinators: Nate Woody, Courtney Braswell
Location: Cincinnati, Ohio - Stadium: Nippert Stadium (38,088)



EVAN TENGESDAHL

SCOUTING THE BEARCATS

"Losing [quarterback Brendan Sorsby] to Texas Tech is a major loss. He was the engine of that team. He made that team go with his ability to pass the ball, and he helped in the run game a lot. He was just a dynamic player for them. He wasn't an NFL quarterback in terms of throwing the football, but he was a really good athlete, and he's a winner. Losing him just shows you in this conference, not everybody is playing by the same rules with revenue sharing. It's the haves and the have-nots. ... I'm very intrigued by their defensive coordinator hire [Nate Woody]. He's got a great track record at Army, and he's had really good numbers."

— An opposing Big 12 assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (3)

WR	11	JV Gibson* (Sr.)	18	Giyahni Kontosis (Fr.)
WR	0	Isaiah Johnson (Jr.)	8	Cade Wolford* (So.)
WR	2	Lorenzo Fenner* (Jr.)	9	Malachi Henry* (Jr.)
LT	74	JOE COTTON (SR.)	72	Nolan Latulippe (Jr.)
LG	50	EVAN TENGESDAHL (JR.)	59	Jake Wheelock (So.)
C	77	TARAN TYO (SR.)	78	Grant Edgington (Jr.)
RG	66	Xavier Lozowicki (Jr.)	73	Aiden Pastoriza (So.)
RT	71	Judea Milon (Sr.)	63	Zac Clarke (So.)
TE	87	Gavin Grover (Jr.)	82	Ka'Maurri Smith (Fr.)
QB	4	JC French IV* (Sr.)	5	Samaj Jones (So.)
RB	13	Zion Johnson (Fr.)	6	Gi'Bran Payne* (Sr.)

DEFENSE (1)

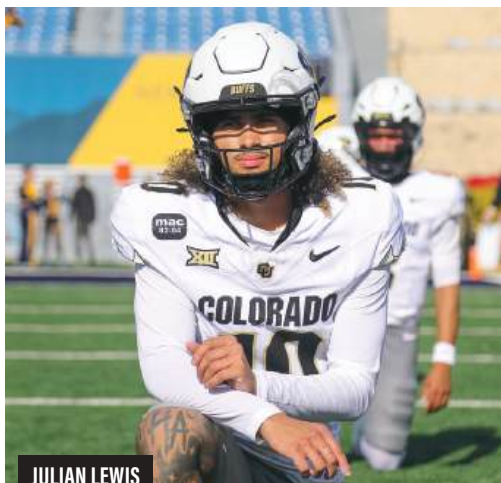
DE	4	Marquaze Parker (Jr.)	16	Jaylon White-McClain (Sr.)
DT	11	Chidera Otutu* (Jr.)	92	Elijah Gunn (Jr.)
DT	95	Josh Hough* (Sr.)	88	CD McFee (Fr.)
OLB	54	Thomas Johnson* (Sr.)	17	Brian Simms III (Jr.)
ILB	12	Filip Maciorowski* (Jr.)	9	Damaine Wilson* (So.)
ILB	22	JONATHAN THOMPSON (SR.)	31	Simeon Coleman (Jr.)
CB	0	Jacob Finley* (Sr.)	25	Daniel James (So.)
CB	8	Kenny Worthy* (So.)	6	Zay Johnson (So.)
NB	3	Antwan Peek Jr. (Sr.)	5	Marqavious Saboor (Jr.)
S	7	Ty Goodwill* (Jr.)	18	Jasper Beeler* (Sr.)
S	2	MJ Cannon* (Sr.)	19	CJ Jones (Fr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	99	Stephen Rusnak (Sr.)	KR	0	Isaiah Johnson (Jr.)
P	31	Max Fletcher (Sr.)	PR	0	Isaiah Johnson (Jr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER

MATTHEW VISINSKY/ICON SPORTSWIRE VIA GETTY IMAGES



JULIAN LEWIS

SCOUTING THE BUFFALOES

"They're interesting because you've got a young, hungry offensive coordinator who was a head coach [Brennan Marion], which is great experience. I love the defensive coordinator hire, Chris Marve. I really like some of their skill players that they have. They're always gonna have receivers and DBs. That's just Deion's deal. ... It's really gonna depend on if they can protect the passer and how good can [Julian Lewis] be in Year 2 while still being a young guy. You just watch them on tape last year, and they didn't do one thing to help the O-line, help the quarterback to get the ball out to the perimeter or moving the pocket. They get schemed up every week from a protection standpoint. Now, with a new coordinator, you'd hope that would change somewhat."

— An opposing Big 12 assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (4)

WR	18	Danny Scudero* (Sr.)	3	DeAndre Moore Jr.* (Sr.)
WR	8	JOSEPH WILLIAMS (JR.)	7	Kam Perry* (Sr.)
LT	55	Bo Hughley* (Jr.)	57	Leon Bell* (Sr.)
LG	51	Chauncey Gooden (Fr.)	71	Jayvon McFadden* (Fr.)
C	58	Demetrius Hunter* (Sr.)	62	Sean Kinney* (Jr.)
RG	59	Yahya Attia (So.)	73	Jose Soto* (Jr.)
RT	54	Taj White* (Sr.)	53	LARRY JOHNSON III (SR.)
TE	85	ZACH ATKINS (SR.)	89	Fisher Clements* (Sr.)
QB	10	Julian Lewis (Fr.)	16	Isaac Wilson* (So.)
RB	20	DeKalon Taylor (Sr.)	29	MICAH WELCH (JR.)
RB	26	Damian Henderson II* (Jr.)	9	Richard Young* (Jr.)

DEFENSE (0)

DE	53	Toby Anene* (Sr.)	45	Vili Taufatofua* (Sr.)
DT	97	Santana Hopper* (Sr.)	49	Quency Wiggins (Sr.)
DT	88	Samu Taumanupepe* (Jr.)	91	Sedrick Smith* (Jr.)
DE	96	Balansama Kamara* (Sr.)	56	Lamont Lester Jr.* (So.)
ILB	35	Tyler Martinez* (Sr.)	44	Gideon Lampron* (Sr.)
ILB	17	Liona Lefau* (Sr.)	50	Rodney Colton Jr. (Fr.)
CB	20	Cree Thomas* (Fr.)	30	Justin Eaglin* (Sr.)
CB	5	RJ Johnson (Jr.)	10	Makari Vickers (Jr.)
NB	6	Boo Carter* (Jr.)	31	Preston Ashley (Fr.)
S	4	Naeten Mitchell* (Jr.)	28	Ben Finneseth (Sr.)
S	7	Randon Fontenette* (Sr.)	9	Jaydan Hardy* (Jr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	46	Elliot Arnold (Fr.)	KR	6	Quentin Gibson (So.)
P	35	Damon Greaves (Sr.)	PR	6	Boo Carter* (Jr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



COLORADO BUFFALOES

NATIONAL FORECAST: 64 | BIG 12 PREDICTION: 14 | 2025 RECORD: 3-9, 1-8 BIG 12

OFFENSE Following a dismal season on offense last year, head coach Deion Sanders hired former Sacramento State head coach Brennan Marion, the creator of the Go-Go attack, as offensive coordinator. Marion's scheme, which relies on a strong run game and vertical shots in the passing game, has been highly productive at multiple stops.

Former 5-star recruit Julian "JuJu" Lewis showed some promise in a pair of starts late last year and could be the starter at quarterback, but Utah transfer Isaac Wilson is pushing for the job. They have several intriguing weapons, including San José State transfer Danny Scudero, who led the country last season with 1,297 receiving yards.

Running backs DeKalon Taylor, Damian Henderson II and Richard Young stood out in spring, while Micah Welch led the Buffs in rushing last year. At receiver, transfers DeAndre Moore Jr., Kam Perry and Ernest Campbell and returner Joseph Williams are set to contribute. Tight end Zach Atkins could be a big part of the passing game, too.

The offensive line will have at least four new starters. CU brought in eight transfer linemen, led by former Houston center Demetrius Hunter.

DEFENSE It's been a complete overhaul this offseason, with former Virginia Tech coordinator Chris Marve now leading the defense. He'll have almost a clean slate to work with, as only five scholarship players on the entire defense are back from last year, none of whom were full-time starters.

Up front, defensive tackle Santana Hopper, who was first-team All-American Conference at Tulane, leads the way, while some former FCS stars — Toby Anene (North Dakota State), Balansama Kamara (UAlbany) and Lamont Lester Jr. (Monmouth) — spearhead the pass rush.

Linebacker Liona Lefau was a two-year starter at Texas and leads in the middle. Defensive back Boo Carter had a rocky ride at Tennessee, but he had a big spring for the Buffs, and Notre Dame transfer Cree Thomas has star potential at cornerback. Transfers Randon Fontenette (Vanderbilt) and Naeten Mitchell (New Mexico State) bring leadership at safety.

SPECIALISTS Senior punter Damon Greaves is back after a solid first year. Alejandro Mata, Sanders' placekicker the past four years including in 2022 at FCS Jackson State, has graduated. Redshirt freshman Elliot Arnold has a strong leg and is ready to take over. Carter could help as a returner.

FINAL ANALYSIS The honeymoon is most certainly over for Sanders, and Buff Nation wants wins and a bowl game. There are no big stars on hand, but it's a roster filled with enough talent to exceed expectations. The early-season schedule is difficult, but if this group comes together, it could pull off a surprise or two and build some momentum.

2025 RESULTS (3-9, 1-8 BIG 12)

Aug. 29	Georgia Tech	L	20-27
Sept. 6	Delaware	W	31-7
Sept. 12	at Houston	L	20-36
Sept. 20	Wyoming	W	37-20
Sept. 27	BYU	L	21-24
Oct. 4	at TCU	L	21-35
Oct. 11	Iowa State	W	24-17
Oct. 25	at Utah	L	7-53
Nov. 1	Arizona	L	17-52
Nov. 8	at West Virginia	L	22-29
Nov. 22	Arizona State	L	17-42
Nov. 29	at Kansas State	L	14-24

2026 SCHEDULE

Sept. 5	at Georgia Tech
Sept. 12	Weber State
Sept. 19	at Northwestern
Sept. 26	at Baylor
Oct. 3	Texas Tech
Oct. 17	Utah
Oct. 24	at Oklahoma State
Oct. 31	Kansas State
Nov. 7	at Arizona State
Nov. 14	Houston
Nov. 21	at Cincinnati
Nov. 28	UCF

TOP 10 RECRUITS*

1. Carson Crawford, LB	★★★★
2. Alex Ward, ATH	★★★★
3. Rodney Colton Jr., LB	★★★★
4. Kaneal Sweetwyne, QB	★★★★
5. Preston Ashley, S	★★★★
6. Braylon Edwards, CB	★★★★
7. Domata Peko Jr., EDGE	★★★★
8. Christian Ward, WR	★★★★
9. Xavier Payne, OT	★★★★
10. Ben Gula, IOL	★★★★

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Deion Sanders • Record at School: 16-21 (3 years) • Career Record: 43-27 (6 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Brennan Marion • Defensive Coordinator: Chris Marve • Location: Boulder, Colo. • Stadium: Folsom Field (50,183)



DREW SURGES

SCOUTING THE CYCLONES

"They'll feel the loss of [former head coach] Matt Campbell more than the loss of [QB] Rocco Becht this year because of how many players and recruits they took [to Penn State]. You've also gotta count how many kids they lost to high school recruiting with them getting out of their NILs. Man, it is really, really hard to replace that amount of guys that late. ... [New head coach] Jimmy Rogers is a really good coach. I mean, he beat North Dakota State when he was at South Dakota State. Even when he was at Washington State last year, he didn't have a really good draw. They didn't have any money. He's a good coach, but it's just gonna take time, especially because of how late he got the job."

— An opposing Big 12 assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (O)

WR	9	Omari Hayes* (Jr.)	4	Carter Pabst* (So.)
WR	11	Dominic Overby (So.)	8	Evan Boyd* (Jr.)
WR	13	Cody Jackson* (Sr.)	17	Jordyn Bailey* (Jr.)
LT	79	Jake Taylor* (Jr.)	71	Gabriel Greenlee (Sr.)
LG	78	DeAndre Carter* (So.)	72	Austin Barrett (Jr.)
C	63	Braden Smith* (So.)	54	Cade Myer* (Sr.)
RG	77	Caden Maas* (Jr.)	74	Gavin Broschious* (Jr.)
RT	56	Colin Amick* (So.)	70	Gavin Proudfoot* (Sr.)
TE	18	Tyler Fortenberry* (Sr.)	85	Keaton Roskop (So.)
QB	1	Jaylen Raynor* (Sr.)	6	Zane Flores* (So.)
RB	0	Cameron Pettaway* (So.)	21	Aiden Flora (So.)

DEFENSE (O)

DE	88	Isaac Terrell* (Sr.)	55	Jace J. Gilbert (So.)
DT	0	Zaimir Hawk (Jr.)	95	Ka'Mori Moore (Fr.)
DT	99	Bryson Lamb* (Sr.)	97	Max Baloun* (Sr.)
DE	92	Caden Crawford* (Sr.)	98	Malaki Ta'ase* (Jr.)
SLB	16	Malcolm Jones* (Sr.)	11	Willie Breland III* (Jr.)
MLB	7	Sullivan Schlimgen* (So.)	8	Tristan Exline* (Sr.)
WLB	10	Carson Willich (Sr.)	31	Montreze Smith Jr.* (So.)
CB	18	David Coffey (So.)	3	Seth Johnson* (So.)
CB	1	Keyon Washington* (So.)	20	Trillion Sorrell* (Fr.)
SS	6	Drew Surges (Jr.)	4	Micah Harper* (Sr.)
FS	21	Duhron Goodman* (Sr.)	14	Damarius Russell* (Fr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	97	Kyle Konrardy (Jr.)	KR	0	Cameron Pettaway* (So.)
P	95	Ethan Gurney (Fr.)	PR	21	Aiden Flora (So.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN **BOLD** • *2026 TRANSFER



IOWA STATE CYCLONES

NATIONAL FORECAST: 70 | BIG 12 PREDICTION: 16 | 2025 RECORD: 8-4, 5-4 BIG 12

OFFENSE Three-year starting quarterback Rocco Becht followed former head coach Matt Campbell to Penn State, leaving Arkansas State transfer Jaylen Raynor to take over. Raynor threw for 3,361 yards and 19 touchdowns in 2025 and brings experience to a new system led by a former Campbell staffer — offensive coordinator Tyler Roehl, who returns to Ames after a stint with the Detroit Lions. Roehl's scheme is expected to lean more on downhill rushing and play-action passing.

The skill positions feature a mix of returnees and intriguing additions. Aiden Flora is back at running back and will get help from Bowling Green transfer Cameron Pettaway, the 2025 MAC Freshman of the Year. At receiver, Dominic Overby returns, while Tulane transfer Omari Hayes and FCS Tarleton State's Cody Jackson add needed explosiveness.

The offensive line will be almost entirely rebuilt. Oklahoma transfer Jake Taylor, Montana's Colin Amick and Tarleton State's Braden Smith — an FCS All-American as a redshirt freshman — headline a group that must come together quickly for this offense to fully click.

DEFENSE Iowa State suffered a crippling injury in the spring when Toledo transfer safety Braden Awls went down with a torn ACL. The only good news is that the staff will have all summer to develop talent to replace him.

Despite heavy turnover, Iowa State retained several key contributors, including defensive linemen Zaimir Hawk and Jace J. Gilbert, linebacker Carson Willich and defensive backs David Coffey and Drew Surges.

New head coach Jimmy Rogers and defensive coordinator Jesse Bobbit also brought familiarity with them from Washington State. Linebacker Sullivan Schlimgen, defensive linemen Max Baloun, Isaac Terrell (7.0 sacks in 2025) and Malaki Ta'ase, along with defensive backs Duhron Goodman and Trillion Sorrell, should play significant roles in the rotation.

SPECIALISTS Junior placekicker Kyle Konrardy is one of the best in the country and gives Iowa State a reliable scoring option. Pettaway, who led the nation with a 33.0-yard kickoff return average, adds explosiveness to the return game, while Flora averaged 26.1 yards per punt return with a touchdown. Australian Ethan Gurney will compete for the punting job.

FINAL ANALYSIS More than 50 Cyclones entered the transfer portal, including 16 starters and a staggering total of 24 players who followed Campbell to Happy Valley. Rogers wasted no time reshaping the roster. More than 45 transfers arrived in Ames, giving the Cyclones one of the most transformed teams in the country. With that level of turnover, 2026 represents a full reset, but there's enough incoming talent to remain competitive in the always-changing Big 12.

2025 RESULTS (8-4, 5-4 BIG 12)

Aug. 23	vs. Kansas State #	W	24-21
Aug. 30	South Dakota	W	55-7
Sept. 6	Iowa	W	16-13
Sept. 13	at Arkansas State	W	24-16
Sept. 27	Arizona	W	39-14
Oct. 4	at Cincinnati	L	30-38
Oct. 11	at Colorado	L	17-24
Oct. 25	BYU	L	27-41
Nov. 1	Arizona State	L	19-24
Nov. 8	at TCU	W	20-17
Nov. 22	Kansas	W	38-14
Nov. 29	at Oklahoma State	W	20-13

#Dublin, Ireland

2026 SCHEDULE

Sept. 5	Southeast Missouri
Sept. 12	at Iowa
Sept. 19	Bowling Green
Sept. 26	Utah
Oct. 3	West Virginia
Oct. 10	at BYU
Oct. 24	at Arizona
Oct. 31	Oklahoma State
Nov. 7	at Baylor
Nov. 14	Cincinnati
Nov. 21	at UCF
Nov. 28	Kansas State

TOP 10 RECRUITS*

1. Benji Makelela, OT	★★★★
2. Bradley Esser, LB	★★★★
3. Jeffrey Roberts, WR	★★★★
4. Malcolm Watkins, WR	★★★★
5. Jamal Polite Jr., WR	★★★★
6. Tayten Duncan, S	★★★★
7. Brady Hummel, ATH	★★★★
8. Hudson Kurland, QB	★★★★
9. Daniel Howard, DL	★★★★
10. Gabriel Wilson, RB	★★★★

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Jimmy Rogers • Record at School: First Season • Career Record: 33-9 (3 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Tyler Roehl • Defensive Coordinator: Jesse Bobbit • Location: Ames, Iowa • Stadium: Jack Trice Stadium (61,500)

OFFENSE Andy Kotelnicki is back as Kansas’ play-caller, but he must replace prolific quarterback Jalon Daniels. Kansas will turn to Cole Ballard, Daniels’ backup in recent years, or dual-threat sophomore Isaiah Marshall. The new QB will share a backfield with Dylan Edwards, a former top-150 recruit and Kansas native who joins his third program after stops at Colorado and Kansas State. “Andy’s really going to enjoy finding different ways to be creative with him,” head coach Lance Leipold says of Edwards.

Kansas has depth at running back with transfers Yasin Willis and Jalen Dupree. Cam Pickett, who tied for the team receptions lead last fall with 45, headlines the wide receiver group along with transfers Nik McMillan and Nahzae Cox. Sophomore tight end Carson Bruhn returns and will team with Old Dominion transfer Jailen Butler.

The O-line returns established starters at left tackle (Calvin Clements) and left guard (Amir Herring) and welcomes a transfer group that includes tackle Nick Morrow (Cal) and Kasen Carpenter (Oklahoma State).

DEFENSE Kansas will try to upgrade a unit that struggled against the run and didn’t generate enough takeaways in 2025. Leipold likes the depth at defensive end with top pass-rusher Leroy Harris III, Alex Bray and Dakyus Brinkley joining Michigan State transfer David Santiago. Blake Herold, who had five tackles for a loss in 2025, leads the defensive tackles.

The defense has a centerpiece in linebacker Trey Lathan, who had a team-high 86 tackles, seven for a loss, an interception, a forced fumble and two fumble recoveries. Leipold expects transfers Bam Crouch (Boston College) and Jibreel Al-Amin (Marshall) to help on the outside.

In the secondary, Austin Alexander, Jalen Todd, Taylor Davis and Syeed Gibbs return, and Kansas added several transfers, including Corey Gordon (Louisville), Roman Pearson (Ball State), Khijohnn Cummings-Coleman (Iowa State) and Jaden Harris (Georgia). “The depth is going to give us opportunities to play more guys and be a fresher defense,” Leipold says.

SPECIALISTS Edwards’ arrival and the return of wide receiver Tate Nagy give Kansas intriguing options in the return game. The team added place-kicker Martin Connington from Michigan State, who connected on 12-of-16 field-goal attempts last year, and Australian punter Matthew Gill.

FINAL ANALYSIS Kansas has some urgency in Leipold’s sixth season. Kotelnicki’s management of the quarterback candidates, Edwards and a potentially deeper offensive line will be key, and Kansas also could have greater depth at all three levels on defense. An opening stretch that features Missouri at home and Arizona State in London could shape the season.

2025 RESULTS (5-7, 3-6 BIG 12)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 23	Fresno State	W	31-7	Sept. 4	Long Island	1. Kaden Snyder, IOL	★★★★
Aug. 29	Wagner	W	46-7	Sept. 12	Missouri	2. Kory Amachree, RB	★★★
Sept. 6	at Missouri	L	31-42	Sept. 19	vs. Arizona State #	3. Draeden Punt, EDGE	★★★
Sept. 20	West Virginia	W	41-10	Oct. 3	Middle Tennessee	4. Nakwaie Carter, DL	★★★
Sept. 27	Cincinnati	L	34-37	Oct. 10	at Utah	5. Kevin Sullivan, TE	★★★
Oct. 4	at UCF	W	27-20	Oct. 17	at Kansas State	6. Hunter Higgins, EDGE	★★★
Oct. 11	at Texas Tech	L	17-42	Oct. 24	Baylor	7. Jack Utz, TE	★★★
Oct. 25	Kansas State	L	17-42	Oct. 31	at TCU	8. Nate Sims, WR	★★★
Nov. 1	Oklahoma State	W	38-21	Nov. 7	UCF	9. Tyren Parker, WR	★★★
Nov. 8	at Arizona	L	20-24	Nov. 14	at West Virginia	10. Josh Galbreath, LB	★★★
Nov. 22	at Iowa State	L	14-38	Nov. 21	BYU		
Nov. 28	Utah	L	21-31	Nov. 28	at Oklahoma State		
				#London, England		*Per Rivals	
TEAM INFORMATION							
Head Coach: Lance Leipold • Record at School: 27-35 (5 years) • Career Record: 173-74 (19 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Andy Kotelnicki • Defensive Coordinator: D.K. McDonald • Location: Lawrence, Kan. • Stadium: David Booth Kansas Memorial Stadium (52,530)							



LEROY HARRIS III

SCOUTING THE JAYHAWKS

“They’re intriguing. You’re no longer the old Kansas, obviously, and now every week, people know that you’re not the old Kansas, and you still get everyone’s best. They have money in the program now. [Head coach] Lance Leipold has some juice. I know that they lost a safety in the portal, and I don’t know what to make of their quarterback situation, but Leipold brought back his old offensive coordinator [Andy Kotelnicki] from Penn State. That’s gonna be good because they also kept their quarterbacks coach [Jim Zebrowski]. When Leipold has had the most success, it’s been when he’s paired with Kotelnicki.”

— An opposing Big 12 assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (2)

WR	7	Cam Pickett (Sr.)	11	Tate Nagy (So.)
WR	5	Nik McMillan* (Sr.)	3	Keaton Kubecka (Jr.)
WR	0	Nahzae Cox* (Sr.)	84	Jaden Nickens (Fr.)
LT	75	CALVIN CLEMENTS (JR.)	78	Brandon Solis* (Jr.)
LG	56	AMIR HERRING (JR.)	54	Tavake Tuikolovatu (Jr.)
C	51	Kasen Carpenter* (Jr.)	73	Anderson Kopp (Fr.)
RG	79	Connor Stroh* (Jr.)	72	DeAndre Harper (So.)
RT	52	Nick Morrow* (Jr.)	74	Jack Tanner (So.)
TE	44	Carson Bruhn (So.)	9	Jailen Butler* (Sr.)
QB	15	Cole Ballard (Jr.)	8	Isaiah Marshall (So.)
RB	1	Dylan Edwards* (Jr.)	6	Yasin Willis* (Jr.)

DEFENSE (4)

DE	33	Leroy Harris III (Jr.)	44	David Santiago* (Jr.)
DT	94	Blake Herold (Jr.)	56	Marcus Calvin (Jr.)
DT	95	Tre’von McAlpine* (Sr.)	99	Eamon Smalls* (Jr.)
DE	91	Alex Bray (Sr.)	9	Dakyus Brinkley (So.)
LB	7	Bam Crouch* (Sr.)	25	Jibreel Al-Amin* (Sr.)
LB	4	TREY LATHAN (SR.)	13	Quincy Davis* (Jr.)
CB	0	AUSTIN ALEXANDER (SO.)	6	Jahlil Hurley (Jr.)
CB	1	JALEN TODD (JR.)	5	Roman Pearson* (Sr.)
NB	2	Syeed Gibbs (Sr.)	22	Khijohnn Cummings-Coleman* (So.)
S	3	Corey Gordon* (Sr.)	20	Christian Pritchett* (Jr.)
S	27	TAYLOR DAVIS (JR.)	12	Jaden Harris* (Sr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	29	Martin Connington* (So.)	KR	1	Dylan Edwards* (Jr.)
P	99	Matthew Gill (Fr.)	PR	11	Tate Nagy (So.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • 2026 TRANSFER



AVERY JOHNSON

SCOUTING THE WILDCATS

"I'm interested to see if [new head coach] Collin Klein takes the old Kansas State approach where it's 12 personnel, two-tight end offense, or kind of what he did at Texas A&M, which is get the ball out in space in 11 personnel. They lost a lot of players in the portal. So with the guys that he signed, what does he want to run? Is it gonna be run the ball, run the ball, power run, use the tight ends, play-action pass? Or is it more 11 personnel, gun-run, get the ball in space? We'll find out what [Klein] really wants to focus on."

— An opposing Big 12 assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (5)

WR	12	JARON TIBBS (SR.)	15	Derrick Salley Jr. (Jr.)
WR	5	Josh Manning* (Sr.)	17	Adonis Moise (So.)
WR	1	Izaiah Williams* (So.)	8	Brandon White* (Sr.)
LT	78	JOHN PASTORE (SR.)	59	George Fitzpatrick (Sr.)
LG	77	Tanner Morley* (Jr.)	79	Charlie Adams* (Jr.)
C	57	Delvin Morris* (Jr.)	55	Kyle Rakers (So.)
RG	71	Dylan Villarouel (Fr.)	54	Keiton Jones* (Fr.)
RT	70	Gus Hawkins (So.)	73	Oliver Miller (Fr.)
TE	86	GARRETT OAKLEY (SR.)	0	Linkon Cure (So.)
QB	2	AVERY JOHNSON (SR.)	3	Blake Barnett (So.)
RB	4	JOE JACKSON (JR.)	20	Rodney Fields Jr.* (So.)

DEFENSE (2)

DE	1	Wendell Gregory* (So.)	30	Dalton Knapp (Fr.)
NT	15	Kamari Burns* (Jr.)	75	Holden Bass (So.)
DT	39	Travis Bates (Sr.)	88	De'Arieun Hicks* (So.)
DE	91	Jordan Allen (Jr.)	56	Elijah Hill* (So.)
LB	4	Mekhi Mason* (Sr.)	35	Gabe Powers (Sr.)
LB	28	Rex Van Wyhe (Sr.)	6	Darien Whitaker Jr. (Fr.)
CB	25	ZASHON RICH (JR.)	7	Kaleb Patterson* (Sr.)
CB	9	DONOVAN MCINTOSH (JR.)	12	Serious Stinyard (Fr.)
NB	3	Ja'Son Prevard* (Sr.)	29	Josiah Vilmael (Fr.)
S	2	Adrian Maddox* (Sr.)	0	Koy Beasley* (So.)
S	10	Logan Bartley (So.)	18	Wesley Fair (Jr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	43	Luis Rodriguez (Jr.)	KR	21	Bryce Noernberg (So.)
P	29	Dylan Davidson* (So.)	PR	6	Sterling Lockett (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



KANSAS STATE WILDCATS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 31 | BIG 12 PREDICTION: 5 | 2025 RECORD: 6-6, 5-4 BIG 12

OFFENSE Avery Johnson, the single-season leader and career co-leader for touchdown passes at Kansas State, is back for his senior season at quarterback. Once he got more usage in the running game last season, the offense performed measurably better. But 2025 was still an underwhelming year for him, likely the product of working with his third offensive coordinator in three years and missing key offensive weapons through most of the season. Reuniting with new head coach and former K-State offensive coordinator Collin Klein should provide a big boost to his game.

Joe Jackson started slowly at running back last season, but he came on strong, rushing for a school-record 293 yards against Utah. Rodney Fields Jr. transferred from Oklahoma State to make a reliable top two.

Jaron Tibbs was a surprisingly strong WR2 in 2025 and now takes over the top spot. Upside transfers like Josh Manning and Izaiah Williams will play significant roles as well. Former 5-star recruit Linkon Cure could be the X-factor with his involvement either as a tight end or spread out wide.

The offensive line will be the key in 2026 after the Wildcats lost most of their starters and were forced to turn to the portal for reinforcements.

DEFENSE K-State had to focus its portal attention on virtually every position after losing nearly all of its defensive starters from 2025. The defensive end and safety spots got the most attention, including the addition of Wendell Gregory from Oklahoma State, the sixth-ranked edge defender in the portal. His performance, along with that of prolific pressure-applier Elijah Hill, will be one of two critically important positions that must excel for the defense to have a strong season. The other is at corner, where the Wildcats will return Zashon Rich and Donovan McIntosh.

The Wildcats have seemingly addressed the pass rush and pass defense, so stopping the run will be the biggest question mark for the new-look defense.

SPECIALISTS Special teams have taken a big step back over the last few seasons at K-State. Bryce Noernberg's burst as a kick returner is a good foundation, but he had some turnover problems in 2025. Placekicking shouldn't be an issue, but winning field position with punting will be the biggest factor on special teams. In each of the past three seasons, K-State has finished in the bottom half of the Big 12 in net punting.

FINAL ANALYSIS Klein, a Heisman Trophy-contending quarterback for the Wildcats during his playing days, returns to Manhattan as the favorite son, but fans should be patient. The offense should be Big 12-caliber, but crucial holes in the defense may prevent K-State from competing for a league title in Klein's first season.

2025 RESULTS (6-6, 5-4 BIG 12)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 23	vs. Iowa State #	L	21-24	Sept. 5	Nicholls	1. Josiah Vilmael, CB	★★★★
Aug. 30	North Dakota	W	38-35	Sept. 12	Washington State	2. Max Lovett, WR	★★★★
Sept. 6	Army	L	21-24	Sept. 19	Tulane	3. Arley Morrell, TE	★★★★
Sept. 12	at Arizona	L	17-23	Sept. 26	at Cincinnati	4. Keegan Collins, OT	★★★★
Sept. 27	UCF	W	34-20	Oct. 10	Houston	5. DJ Ackerson Jr., LB	★★★★
Oct. 4	at Baylor	L	34-35	Oct. 17	Kansas	6. Nick McClellan, S	★★★★
Oct. 11	TCU	W	41-28	Oct. 24	at Arizona State	7. Lamarcus Barber, IOL	★★★★
Oct. 25	at Kansas	W	42-17	Oct. 31	at Colorado	8. Tucker Ashford, EDGE	★★★★
Nov. 1	Texas Tech	L	20-43	Nov. 7	Oklahoma State	9. Oliver Miller, OT	★★★★
Nov. 15	at Oklahoma State	W	14-6	Nov. 14	at TCU	10. Derrick Salley Jr., WR	★★★★
Nov. 22	at Utah	L	47-51	Nov. 21	Arizona		
Nov. 29	Colorado	W	24-14	Nov. 28	at Iowa State		
#Dublin, Ireland				*Per Rivals			

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Collin Klein • Record at School: First Season • Career Record: First Season • Offensive Coordinator: Sean Gleeson
Defensive Coordinator: Jordan Peterson • Location: Manhattan, Kan. • Stadium: Bill Snyder Family Football Stadium (50,000)



OKLAHOMA STATE COWBOYS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 36 | BIG 12 PREDICTION: 8 | 2025 RECORD: 1-11, 0-9 BIG 12

OFFENSE The core of the Oklahoma State offense followed new head coach Eric Morris from North Texas. Quarterback Drew Mestemaker led the nation in passing yards for the Mean Green last year at 4,379 yards and will try to replicate that production with the Cowboys.

Running back Caleb Hawkins set the FBS record for touchdowns by a freshman with 29 at North Texas last season, to go with 1,434 rushing yards. Another North Texas transfer, receiver Wyatt Young, was Mestemaker's favorite target, finishing with 1,264 receiving yards last season. Transfers Justin Bowick from Illinois and Chris Barnes from Wake Forest arrive with high expectations of fitting well into a pass-happy offense.

While the offensive line has some veterans, their development and chemistry will be critical. Incoming transfers like Jacob Sexton from Oklahoma, Tyler Mercer from Kansas, Joseph Hanson from Coastal Carolina and a trio of players from North Texas will be among those tasked with protecting Mestemaker.

DEFENSE Less is known about the direction the defense will take under Skyler Cassity, who at 32 is one of the youngest defensive coordinators in the nation. In his one season at North Texas, he trimmed the Mean Green's points allowed per game by nearly 10 from the previous year.

Cassity uses multiple fronts and often likes to put five defensive backs on the field. His front will feature a talented group of edge rushers, including Jaleel Johnson and James Williams, as well as proven, productive linebackers like Ethan Wesloski, Tate Romney and Isaiah Chisom.

The secondary has a blend of veterans like cornerback Mo Horn and safety Quinton Hammonds, and emerging young players such as cornerback LaDainian Fields and true freshman safety Braeden Presley.

SPECIALISTS Morris brought in an entirely new group of specialists, beginning with placekicker Sam Keltner from SMU, who will be asked to increase his consistency after going 14-of-20 on field goals as a redshirt freshman last season. Australian punter Lachie Pozzobon showed a knack for accuracy and hangtime while averaging 41.8 yards per punt as a freshman at FCS Stephen F. Austin. Barnes will be the biggest threat in the return game, where he posted some highlight-reel plays at Wake Forest.

FINAL ANALYSIS Morris' track record for offensive success was a big reason for his hiring, and the offense will be expected to produce from the start. Morris brought in 18 players from North Texas, so there could be growing pains, but this is Morris' third stop as a head coach, so he understands the challenges of building a program. The Cowboys went winless in Big 12 play the past two seasons, so the bar for improvement remains low.

2025 RESULTS (1-11, 0-9 BIG 12)	2026 SCHEDULE	TOP 10 RECRUITS*
Aug. 28 Tennessee-Martin W 27-7	Sept. 5 at Tulsa	1. KD Jones, RB ★★★
Sept. 6 at Oregon L 3-69	Sept. 12 Oregon	2. Braeden Presley, S ★★★
Sept. 19 Tulsa L 12-19	Sept. 19 Murray State	3. Landon Bland, EDGE ★★★
Sept. 27 Baylor L 27-45	Sept. 26 at West Virginia	4. Luke Tepas, QB ★★★
Oct. 4 at Arizona L 13-41	Oct. 10 UCF	5. Eli Holbrook, IOL ★★★
Oct. 11 Houston L 17-39	Oct. 17 at Houston	6. Jani Weir, WR ★★★
Oct. 18 Cincinnati L 17-49	Oct. 24 Colorado	7. Kole Seaton, OT ★★★
Oct. 25 at Texas Tech L 0-42	Oct. 31 at Iowa State	8. Jabarie Thornton, WR ★★★
Nov. 1 at Kansas L 21-38	Nov. 7 at Kansas State	9. Broderick Vehrs, QB ★★★
Nov. 15 Kansas State L 6-14	Nov. 14 Texas Tech	10. Joey Quinn, EDGE ★★★
Nov. 22 at UCF L 14-17	Nov. 21 at Arizona State	
Nov. 29 Iowa State L 13-20	Nov. 28 Kansas	

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Eric Morris • Record at School: First Season • Career Record: 46-34 (7 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Sean Brophy • Defensive Coordinator: Skyler Cassity • Location: Stillwater, Okla. • Stadium: Boone Pickens Stadium (53,885)



LADAINIAN FIELDS

SCOUTING THE COWBOYS

"Yes, [the North Texas offense] can translate to the Big 12 because of the trigger man. [North Texas transfer] Drew Mestemaker is special. He's got great vision, and he's a quick processor. They'll have a chance because he's playing quarterback. Now I know that they brought a lot of players in. I get that, but having that elite quarterback, they'll have a chance. What that means, I don't know. But they'll definitely have a chance on offense. ... [Head coach] Eric Morris has all the right pieces, and he brought pretty much his entire staff from North Texas. I expect them to pick up right where he left off, and he has a background in this conference as well that holds weight."

— An opposing Big 12 assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (O)

WR	0	Justin Bowick* (Sr.)	11	Rodney Harris II* (Sr.)
WR	10	Wyatt Young* (Jr.)	1	Miles Coleman* (Jr.)
WR	2	Chris Barnes* (So.)	84	Matrail Lopez (Fr.)
LT	67	Braydon Nelson* (Jr.)	76	Desmond Magiya* (Jr.)
LG	79	Jacob Sexton* (Sr.)	66	Louie Canepa (Sr.)
C	56	Tyler Mercer* (So.)	75	Jakobe Sanders (Jr.)
RG	54	Johnny Dickson III* (Sr.)	71	Miguel Chavez (Fr.)
RT	68	Joseph Hanson* (Sr.)	77	Ashton Lepo* (Sr.)
TE	81	Donovan Green* (Sr.)	23	Oscar Hammond (Sr.)
QB	17	Drew Mestemaker* (So.)	9	Grant Jordan* (Sr.)
RB	24	Caleb Hawkins* (So.)	6	Tre Page III* (So.)

DEFENSE (I)

DE	95	Jaleel Johnson (Sr.)	87	DeSean Brown (Sr.)
DT	5	Saadique Clements* (Jr.)	45	Enai White* (Sr.)
DT	92	Jerry Lawson* (Sr.)	98	Luke Webb (So.)
DE	8	James Williams* (Sr.)	11	Keviyon Huddleston* (Jr.)
LB	32	Ethan Wesloski* (Sr.)	2	Isaiah Chisom* (Jr.)
LB	3	Tate Romney* (Sr.)	30	Trip White (Sr.)
CB	4	Mo Horn* (Sr.)	22	Kobe Foreman (So.)
CB	9	LADAINIAN FIELDS (SO.)	25	Kollin Lewis* (Jr.)
S	7	Quinton Hammonds* (Jr.)	23	Braeden Presley (Fr.)
S	1	Evan Jackson* (Sr.)	6	Christian Bodnar* (Jr.)
S	27	Vincent Holmes* (Jr.)	12	Cameron Epps (Sr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	16	Sam Keltner* (So.)	KR	2	Chris Barnes* (So.)
P	37	Lachie Pozzobon* (So.)	PR	2	Chris Barnes* (So.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



JAMEL JOHNSON

SCOUTING THE HORNED FROGS

"I still think they have good athletes. They can get the ball in space, and they have great team speed, so that's still gonna be a challenge. But I think the biggest challenge is gonna be when they can play complementary football; they're always on defense. They need to develop some consistency with what they want to do. Can they get to a power-run game to slow down the game? Can they help the defense out when they're tired and they're not having success that game? ... But they have great talent. Great speed. Great running backs. And they have a great offensive system. They can get the ball in space and to their playmakers, and they do a really good job of creating mismatches for the defensive coaches and players."

— An opposing Big 12 assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (4)

WR	7	JORDAN DWYER (SR.)	0	Dozie Ezukanma (So.)
WR	15	Terry Shelton (Fr.)	6	Jeremy Scott* (So.)
WR	18	Ed Small (So.)	3	Major Everhart (Sr.)
LT	56	BEN TAYLOR-WHITFIELD (SR.)	50	Witten Van Hoy (So.)
LG	60	CADE BENNETT (SR.)	73	Kilian Registe (Fr.)
C	59	Jaheim Buchanan* (Jr.)	77	Cooper Powers (Jr.)
RG	58	Noah McKinney* (Sr.)	51	Devan Robison (Fr.)
RT	70	RYAN HUGHES (SO.)	66	Wesley Harvey (So.)
TE	88	Ka'Morreun Pimpton (Jr.)	87	Mason Peterson (So.)
QB	1	Jaden Craig* (Sr.)	11	Adam Schobel (Fr.)
RB	26	Jeremy Payne (Jr.)	2	Jon Denman (So.)

DEFENSE (5)

DE	97	Paul Oyewale (Jr.)	9	Chad Woodfork (Fr.)
DT	95	MARKIS DEAL (JR.)	35	Tristan Johnson (So.)
DT	92	ANSEL DIN-MBUH (SR.)	34	Perry Cole Jr. (Jr.)
STUD	0	ZACH CHAPMAN (JR.)	33	Koron Hayward* (Jr.)
ILB	3	Max Carroll (Jr.)	44	Sam Haley (Fr.)
ILB	27	Michael Teason (Jr.)	11	Michael Short* (Sr.)
CB	1	VERNON GLOVER JR. (JR.)	12	Kalen Carroll* (Sr.)
CB	4	Gil Jackson (So.)	21	Teon Parks* (Sr.)
NB	7	Julius Simms (So.)	6	Kylin Jackson (Jr.)
S	2	JAMEL JOHNSON (SR.)	18	Kaden McFadden (Jr.)
S	22	Jordan Lester (Jr.)	10	Jacob Fields* (Sr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	34	Kyle Lemmermann (So.)	KR	3	Major Everhart (Sr.)
P	48	John Hoyet Chance* (So.)	PR	7	Jordan Dwyer (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



TCU HORNED FROGS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 37 | BIG 12 PREDICTION: 9 | 2025 RECORD: 9-4, 5-4 BIG 12

OFFENSE This will be a year of change, as the Horned Frogs will have a new quarterback and new offensive coordinator. TCU brought in FCS Harvard transfer quarterback Jaden Craig to replace Josh Hoover, who departed for Indiana, while new coordinator Gordon Sammis takes over for Kendal Briles. The Horned Frogs will also have to replace star wide receiver Eric McAlister, a first-team All-Big 12 selection last season.

The Frogs remain optimistic that they'll be productive in Sammis' pro-style scheme. TCU returns leading rusher Jeremy Payne, who emerged in the final stretch of the season with two 100-yard games in the final four, and second-leading receiver Jordan Dwyer, who had 730 yards and seven touchdowns last season. Young wideouts Terry Shelton and Dozie Ezukanma are expected to have bigger roles as well.

The Horned Frogs return three starters on the offensive line and also signed key transfers Noah McKinney and Jaheim Buchanon. Head coach Sonny Dykes believes this could be the deepest offensive line TCU has had during his tenure.

DEFENSE TCU will also need to replace some defensive firepower with the departure of All-Big 12 safety Bud Clark, All-Big 12 linebacker Kaleb Elarms-Orr and veteran Namdi Obiazor. The good news is that TCU retained much of its defensive line, including tackle Markis Deal and end Zach Chapman, after finishing fifth in the Big 12 in rushing defense in '25.

The biggest question mark is linebacker. TCU has one answer in Max Carroll, who will play middle linebacker in Elarms-Orr's spot, but a number of redshirt freshmen and transfers are vying for the second position. TCU also returns All-Big 12 safety Jamel Johnson, who will be the leader of a secondary hoping to improve in 2026. Johnson had 96 tackles and five interceptions last year.

Cornerback was TCU's biggest weakness last season, but improvement could be in the offing thanks to the emergence of Gil Jackson. The 6-foot-3 cornerback was one of the top performers in the spring after earning playing time as a freshman last season. Starter Vernon Glover Jr. also returns, and TCU added two transfers with Power 4 experience.

SPECIALISTS TCU returns starting kicker Kyle Lemmermann and added Louisiana Tech transfer punter John Hoyet Chance. Lemmermann dealt with injuries last season but is hoping for a bounce-back year.

FINAL ANALYSIS TCU has talent across the board, but the loss of star power on both sides could be tough to overcome. The development of Craig in Sammis' system and the emergence of another linebacker will determine the Horned Frogs' ceiling as a Big 12 contender.

2025 RESULTS (9-4, 5-4 BIG 12)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Sept. 1	at North Carolina	W	48-14	Aug. 29	vs. North Carolina #	1. Carter Buck, EDGE	★★★★
Sept. 13	Abilene Christian	W	42-21	Sept. 12	Grambling State	2. Vincent Johnson Jr., IOL	★★★
Sept. 20	SMU	W	35-24	Sept. 19	Arkansas State	3. Devan Robison, IOL	★★★
Sept. 26	at Arizona State	L	24-27	Sept. 26	at UCF	4. Ace Martin, RB	★★★
Oct. 4	Colorado	W	35-21	Oct. 3	BYU	5. Jesse Ford, EDGE	★★★
Oct. 11	at Kansas State	L	28-41	Oct. 17	at Baylor	6. Cooper Reid, WR	★★★
Oct. 18	Baylor	W	42-36	Oct. 24	West Virginia	7. G'Ivori Graham, RB	★★★
Oct. 25	at West Virginia	W	23-17	Oct. 31	Kansas	8. James Scott, TE	★★★
Nov. 8	Iowa State	L	17-20	Nov. 7	at Arizona	9. Zach Taylor, S	★★★
Nov. 15	at BYU	L	13-44	Nov. 14	Kansas State	10. Duncan McGhee, DL	★★★
Nov. 22	at Houston	W	17-14	Nov. 21	Utah	*Per Rivals	
Nov. 29	Cincinnati	W	45-23	Nov. 28	at Texas Tech		
Dec. 30	vs. USC # (ot)	W	30-27				
#Alamo Bowl				#Dublin, Ireland			

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Sonny Dykes • Record at School: 36-17 (4 years) • Career Record: 107-80 (15+ years) • Offensive Coordinators: Gordon Sammis, A.J. Ricker • Defensive Coordinator: Andy Avalos • Location: Fort Worth, Texas • Stadium: Amon G. Carter Stadium (47,000)



TEXAS TECH RED RAIDERS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 12 | BIG 12 PREDICTION: 1 | 2025 RECORD: 12-2, 8-1 BIG 12

OFFENSE With the uncertainty around star quarterback Brendan Sorsby's eligibility, Tulsa transfer Kirk Francis appears to be first in line for the job. Francis started 10 games at Tulsa and racked up 3,045 yards and 18 touchdowns in his 18 total appearances. Redshirt freshman Lloyd Jones III is a backup option who tore his ACL his senior year of high school and appeared in one game in 2025. Will Hammond, last season's backup, is recovering from his own torn ACL, though he is projected to be back sometime early in the season.

The Red Raiders have a fully stocked arsenal around the QB, whoever he is. Running backs Cameron Dickey and J'Koby Williams return following phenomenal sophomore seasons. The tandem combined for nearly 2,000 rushing yards last season and scored 25 total touchdowns.

Texas Tech returns three starters on the offensive line — tackles Howard Sampson and Jacob Ponton and center Sheridan Wilson.

Sorsby has several weapons at his disposal this season, including second-team All-Big 12 tight end Terrance Carter Jr. and Pitt transfer wide receiver Kenny Johnson.

DEFENSE Replacing several NFL Draft picks on the defensive side of the ball is the toughest task Texas Tech is facing this season.

Following in the footsteps of the nation's 2025 sack leader David Bailey are transfers Trey White and Adam Trick. Their production is enticing. White tallied 19.5 sacks the last two seasons at San Diego State, while Trick finished with 12.5 tackles for a loss last season at Miami (Ohio).

The Red Raiders recruited Kansas State linebacker Austin Romaine out of the transfer portal to pair up next to Big 12 Championship Game Most Outstanding Player Ben Roberts. The most important returner on defense, however, is cornerback Brice Pollock. He finished with five interceptions last season and was named first-team All-Big 12.

SPECIALISTS Lou Groza Award semifinalist and All-Big 12 first-teamer Stone Harrington returns for his senior season as the incumbent place-kicker. Harrington won the job last season with a big leg that helped him nail a career-long 58-yard field goal against Utah. The Red Raiders must replace their punter after the graduation of starter Jack Burgess.

FINAL ANALYSIS The schedule presents intriguing measuring sticks with Houston, Arizona and Oklahoma State. It's likely that the Red Raiders will be marginally worse defensively, purely because of the personnel they're losing to the NFL. Still, even without the services of its top signal-caller, Texas Tech's roster is top-to-bottom the most talented in the Big 12.

2025 RESULTS (12-2, 8-1 BIG 12)	2026 SCHEDULE	TOP 10 RECRUITS*
Aug. 30 Arkansas-Pine Bluff W 67-7	Sept. 5 Abilene Christian	1. La'Damion Guyton, EDGE ★★★★★
Sept. 6 Kent State W 62-14	Sept. 12 at Oregon State	2. Chase Campbell, WR ★★★★★
Sept. 13 Oregon State W 45-14	Sept. 19 Houston	3. Felix Ojo, OT ★★★★★
Sept. 20 at Utah W 34-10	Sept. 26 Sam Houston	4. S'Vioarean Martin, CB ★★★★★
Oct. 4 at Houston W 35-11	Oct. 3 at Colorado	5. Matt Ludwig, TE ★★★★★
Oct. 11 Kansas W 42-17	Oct. 17 Arizona State	6. Bryce Gilmore, OT ★★★★★
Oct. 18 at Arizona State L 22-26	Oct. 24 at Cincinnati	7. Ashton Rowden, RB ★★★★★
Oct. 25 Oklahoma State W 42-0	Oct. 31 Arizona	8. Kaegan Ash, LB ★★★★★
Nov. 1 at Kansas State W 43-20	Nov. 7 West Virginia	9. Donovan Webb, S ★★★
Nov. 8 BYU W 29-7	Nov. 14 at Oklahoma State	10. Jacob Crow, OT ★★★
Nov. 15 UCF W 48-9	Nov. 21 at Baylor	
Nov. 29 at West Virginia W 49-0	Nov. 28 TCU	
Dec. 6 vs. BYU # W 34-7		
Jan. 1 vs. Oregon % L 0-23		
*Per Rivals		
TEAM INFORMATION		
Head Coach: Joey McGuire • Record at School: 35-18 (4 years)		
Career Record: 35-18 (4 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Mack Leftwich		
Defensive Coordinators: Shiel Wood, Rob Greene • Location: Lubbock, Texas		
Stadium: Jones AT&T Stadium (60,229)		

#Arlington, TX %Orange Bowl: CFB Playoff Quarterfinal



CAMERON DICKEY

SCOUTING THE RED RAIDERS

"[Brendan Sorsby] is not gonna be able to play, no matter what they say. There's no way because once you open Pandora's Box, it's over. ... It's hard every year when you recruit the portal. Obviously, last year, they hit on all four of those D-linemen. Are they really gonna do that every year? I mean, that's hard. ... [Backup QB] Will Hammond is talented, but we all know with an ACL, it takes a long time to recover. ... I think they're still ultra-talented, so they can still [win the Big 12]. It's just not gonna be easy. To me, it was BYU vs. Texas Tech for the Big 12 championship. Can you say that now? I don't know."

— An opposing Big 12 assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (6)

WR	4	Kenny Johnson* (Sr.)	9	Donte Lee Jr.* (Sr.)
WR	1	Micah Hudson (Jr.)	11	Malcolm Simmons* (Jr.)
WR	3	COY EAKIN (SR.)	6	Jalen Jones* (Jr.)
LT	79	HOWARD SAMPSON (SR.)	78	Ellis Davis (So.)
LG	57	Hunter Zambrano (Sr.)	65	D'Anthis Upshaw Jr. (So.)
C	72	SHERIDAN WILSON (SR.)	52	Cash Cleveland (Jr.)
RG	54	Jordan Church* (Jr.)	61	Connor Carty (Fr.)
RT	70	JACOB PONTON (SO.)	74	Daniel Sill (Jr.)
TE	7	TERRANCE CARTER JR. (SR.)	85	Jett Carpenter (Sr.)
QB	18	Kirk Francis* (Jr.)	10	Lloyd Jones III (Fr.)
RB	8	CAMERON DICKEY (JR.)	20	J'Koby Williams (Jr.)

DEFENSE (5)

DE	2	Trey White* (Sr.)	97	Charles Anderson Jr. (So.)
DT	10	A.J. HOLMES JR. (SR.)	1	Julien Laventure* (Sr.)
DT	98	Mateen Ibirogba* (Sr.)	92	Bryce Butler* (Sr.)
DE	20	Adam Trick* (Sr.)	33	Ansel Nedore (Jr.)
ILB	13	BEN ROBERTS (SR.)	9	Corey Platt Jr.* (Jr.)
ILB	15	Austin Romaine* (Sr.)	11	Brock Golwas (So.)
CB	14	BRICE POLLOCK (SR.)	4	Davin Martin* (Jr.)
CB	27	Amier Boyd (Sr.)	12	Tarrion Grant (So.)
STAR	6	JOHN CURRY (JR.)	22	Marcus Ramon-Edwards (Jr.)
S	7	BRENDEN JORDAN (SR.)	24	Malik Esquerria (So.)
S	3	Peyton Morgan (So.)	5	Oliver Miles III (So.)

SPECIALISTS

K	48	Stone Harrington (Sr.)	KR	20	J'Koby Williams (Jr.)
P	49	Will Karoll* (Sr.)	PR	4	Kenny Johnson* (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



DUANE THOMAS JR.

SCOUTING THE KNIGHTS

"I think that once they get the quarterback situation figured out there, they're going to skyrocket. [Head coach] Scott Frost knows how to win there. Every head coach has won there except for Gus [Malzahn]. But before that, every coach has won big from George O'Leary to Frost, to [current Tennessee head coach] Josh Heupel. They've all won and had a lot of success. ... Frost has a really good offensive scheme, and there are certain players down there [in Florida] that fit his scheme. Once he gets a quarterback at the level that he wants, watch out for them. I'm high on Frost, and I'm high on that program."

— An opposing Big 12 assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (3)

WR	7	DUANE THOMAS JR. (SR.)	6	Ric'Darious Farmer (So.)
WR	9	Waden Charles (So.)	3	Jonathan Bibbs* (So.)
WR	13	Josh Derry* (Sr.)	2	Tyren Hornes (Fr.)
LT	73	Henry Tabansi* (Jr.)	61	Owen Spell (Sr.)
LG	66	Brady Wayburn* (Sr.)	53	LaParka Langston (Jr.)
C	54	Cooper Terpstra* (Jr.)	55	Jacob Maiava (Fr.)
RG	58	Connor Meadows (Sr.)	76	Justin Royes (Jr.)
RT	78	PRESTON CUSHMAN (SR.)	75	Tyler Gibson* (Sr.)
TE	0	DYLAN WADE (SR.)	18	Caden Piening (Fr.)
QB	14	Alonza Barnett III* (Sr.)	12	Keyone Jenkins* (Sr.)
RB	26	Duke Watson* (Jr.)	11	Landen Chambers* (Jr.)

DEFENSE (6)

DE	6	Isaiah Nixon (Jr.)	41	Bruno Dall* (Jr.)
DT	95	RJ JACKSON JR. (SR.)	99	Thomas Collins* (Jr.)
DT	13	Horace Lockett (Sr.)	93	Brad Gurley* (Sr.)
DE	10	Sincere Edwards (Jr.)	11	Ken Talley* (Sr.)
LB	20	LEWIS CARTER (SR.)	24	Tackett Curtis* (Sr.)
LB	34	Jahleel Culbreath* (Sr.)	38	Jayden Jennings (Sr.)
CB	29	JAYDEN BELLAMY (SR.)	5	DJ Bell (Sr.)
CB	7	ANTIONE JACKSON (SR.)	17	Jailen Duffie* (Jr.)
NB	4	BRAEDEN MARSHALL (SR.)	14	Kahmel Johnson* (So.)
S	8	DEMARI HENDERSON (SR.)	21	Ty Bartrum* (Sr.)
S	23	Jayden Williams (Sr.)	18	Caleb Flagg* (Sr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	15	Will Stone* (Sr.)	KR	20	Kaj Baker (Fr.)
P	49	Atticus Bertrams* (Sr.)	PR	7	Antione Jackson (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



UCF KNIGHTS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 65 | BIG 12 PREDICTION: 15 | 2025 RECORD: 5-7, 2-7 BIG 12

OFFENSE After a season of quarterback uncertainty and injuries, UCF is banking on James Madison transfer Alonza Barnett III to stabilize the offense. Barnett was the 2025 Sun Belt Player of the Year after throwing for 2,806 yards, rushing for 589 and accounting for 38 total touchdowns while leading JMU to a College Football Playoff appearance. That kind of proven production is badly needed after UCF averaged just 24.3 points per game in 2025 and scored touchdowns on only 55% of its red-zone trips.

The run game also gets a major reset. Louisville transfer Duke Watson brings explosiveness after averaging 8.9 yards per carry as a freshman in 2024, while FCS Central Arkansas transfer Landen Chambers arrives after a 1,273-yard season. UCF also hopes former top recruit Taevion Swint can make an impact after redshirting in 2025.

There are solid returning pieces in the passing game. Duane Thomas Jr. led UCF with 53 catches for 528 yards; tight end Dylan Wade added 43 receptions for 523 yards and five touchdowns; and Waden Charles contributed 26 catches for 290 yards as a true freshman. FCS Monmouth transfer Josh Derry has the résumé to become the go-to target on the outside.

Up front, right tackle Preston Cushman returns, but the line will again lean heavily on portal additions, including Buffalo transfer Henry Tabansi.

DEFENSE The strength should be the secondary, which returns almost intact. Cornerback Jayden Bellamy had eight breakups and one interception, Antione Jackson added five breakups, Braeden Marshall picked off two passes, and Demari Henderson finished with 61 tackles.

Linebacker Lewis Carter headlines the front seven after leading the team with 92 tackles, while tackles RJ Jackson Jr. and Horace Lockett give UCF experience inside.

The biggest question is edge rusher. UCF posted 27 sacks in 2025, but 10 came from departed veterans Nyjalik Kelly and Malachi Lawrence. Returners Isaiah Nixon and Sincere Edwards should step into larger roles, and UCF will count on Akron transfer Bruno Dall immediately.

SPECIALISTS This is a full reset. Texas transfer Will Stone has a big leg and handled kickoffs for the Longhorns, but he has never attempted a field goal in a college game. Wisconsin transfer Atticus Bertrams brings experience at punter and should help steady the unit.

FINAL ANALYSIS This is an important season for head coach Scott Frost to start showing that his second stint at UCF can look more like his first than his tenure at Nebraska. Barnett gives UCF a proven winner at the game's most important position. If he can steady the offense, bowl eligibility should be a realistic expectation. If not, the questions about Frost's long-term future in Orlando will get louder.

2025 RESULTS (5-7, 2-7 BIG 12)

Aug. 28	Jacksonville State	W	17-10
Sept. 6	North Carolina A&T	W	68-7
Sept. 20	North Carolina	W	34-9
Sept. 27	at Kansas State	L	20-34
Oct. 4	Kansas	L	20-27
Oct. 11	at Cincinnati	L	11-20
Oct. 18	West Virginia	W	45-13
Nov. 1	at Baylor	L	3-30
Nov. 7	Houston	L	27-30
Nov. 15	at Texas Tech	L	9-48
Nov. 22	Oklahoma State	W	17-14
Nov. 29	at BYU	L	21-41

2026 SCHEDULE

Sept. 3	Bethune-Cookman
Sept. 12	at Pitt
Sept. 19	Georgia State
Sept. 26	TCU
Oct. 3	at Houston
Oct. 10	at Oklahoma State
Oct. 24	BYU
Oct. 31	Baylor
Nov. 7	at Kansas
Nov. 14	Arizona State
Nov. 21	Iowa State
Nov. 28	at Colorado

TOP 10 RECRUITS*

1. Rocco Marriott, QB	★★★★
2. Tyren Hornes, WR	★★★★
3. Dante Carr, QB	★★★
4. Noah Mercer, DL	★★★
5. Alhassan Iddrissu, EDGE	★★★
6. Elijah Keys, CB	★★★
7. Kaj Baker, RB	★★★
8. Preston Hall, LB	★★★
9. Amahn Williams, IOL	★★★
10. Amarian Queen, CB	★★★

*Per Rivals

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Scott Frost • Record at School: 24-14 (3 years) • Career Record: 40-45 (7+ years) • Offensive Coordinator: Steve Cooper • Defensive Coordinator: Alex Grinch • Location: Orlando, Fla. • Stadium: Acrisure Bounce House (44,206)



UTAH UTES

NATIONAL FORECAST: 20 | BIG 12 PREDICTION: 4 | 2025 RECORD: 11-2, 7-2 BIG 12

OFFENSE The Utes offense is transitioning from former offensive coordinator Jason Beck to veteran play-caller Kevin McGiven, who arrives from Utah State and will look to maintain a strong run game while attempting to establish a more productive passing attack. Utah welcomes an infusion of proven talent from the portal, including Braden Pegan from Utah State (60 receptions, 926 yards, five touchdowns last season) and Kyri Shoels from San José State, who will complement up-and-coming returners from last season.

Dynamic quarterbacks Devon Dampier and Byrd Ficklin, who return in a “tag-team” effort, highlight the offense, along with leading rusher Wayshawn Parker. But they’ll have to get the job done behind an offensive line that replaces five starters. There’s optimism that the line can still be effective, but the success of the offense will largely depend on how well that line functions this season.

DEFENSE The defense lost several key players from last season’s team to graduation or the portal, but the unit was able to reload in areas of need. A big area of focus — adding more talent to the defensive line after the Utes were gashed in the run game in the latter part of the season. Utah addressed that need in the portal by adding proven players Jireh Moe (San José State) and Lucas Samsula (Wyoming), among others, and the line looks poised for improvement.

Utah added size and physicality to its defensive backs room, while the linebackers provide more versatility than in previous seasons. As a whole, Utah has a veteran defense, one that can provide a bit more versatility for new head coach Morgan Scalley and new defensive coordinator Colton Swan to stress opposing offenses.

SPECIALISTS Utah didn’t need its special teams unit to do too much last year, but Dillon Curtis returns as the team’s placekicker and Orion Phillips as the team’s punter. The two provide consistency and experience to a part of the game that is expected to improve overall. Additionally, Mana Carvalho looks to be a game-changer in the return game with a year of experience under his belt.

FINAL ANALYSIS Utah underwent a major change when Kyle Whittingham stepped away after 21 seasons and accepted the head-coaching job at Michigan. But Scalley has been groomed for the top spot and looks to provide consistency and continuity after several years with the program. He’ll have to do it with a new staff and 18 new faces on the roster in his first season, but his experience with the program should allow for a smooth transition as the Utes pursue a Big 12 title.

2025 RESULTS (11-2, 7-2 BIG 12)			2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 30	at UCLA	W 43-10	Sept. 3	Idaho	1. Kelvin Obot, OT	★★★★★
Sept. 6	Cal Poly	W 63-9	Sept. 12	Arkansas	2. LaMarcus Bell, RB	★★★
Sept. 13	at Wyoming	W 31-6	Sept. 19	Utah State	3. PJ Takitaki, EDGE	★★★
Sept. 20	Texas Tech	L 10-34	Sept. 26	at Iowa State	4. Major Hinchey, CB	★★★
Sept. 27	at West Virginia	W 48-14	Oct. 10	Kansas	5. Kane Archer, QB	★★★
Oct. 11	Arizona State	W 42-10	Oct. 17	at Colorado	6. Mataalii Benjamin, OT	★★★
Oct. 18	at BYU	L 21-24	Oct. 24	Houston	7. Moses Sparks, IOL	★★★
Oct. 25	Colorado	W 53-7	Oct. 31	at Cincinnati	8. Preston Pitts, LB	★★★
Nov. 1	Cincinnati	W 45-14	Nov. 7	BYU	9. Aisa Galea'i, S	★★★
Nov. 15	at Baylor	W 55-28	Nov. 14	at Arizona	10. Brandon Holmes, CB	★★★
Nov. 22	Kansas State	W 51-47	Nov. 21	at TCU		
Nov. 28	at Kansas	W 31-21	Nov. 28	West Virginia		
Dec. 31	vs. Nebraska #	W 44-22				

#Las Vegas Bowl

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Morgan Scalley • Record at School: 1-0 (1 season) • Career Record: 1-0 (1 season) • Offensive Coordinator: Kevin McGiven • Defensive Coordinator: Colton Swan • Location: Salt Lake City, Utah • Stadium: Rice-Eccles Stadium (51,444)



DEVON DAMPIER

SCOUTING THE UTES

“I’m really curious what it looks like without [former head coach] Kyle Whittingham. They cause a lot of mismatches because they’re plus-one in the run game with the quarterback and all the pullers and gap schemes that they did. It’s gonna be really interesting to see what their new philosophy is on offense and defense because they did struggle to stop the run last season. I think they were the worst in the Big 12 against the run last year. That’s not them. They’ve always been great up front, so that’ll be interesting. ... But yeah, it’s definitely a relief that [Whittingham] is out of the Big 12 because he’s a great football coach, and he’s an even better person.”

— An opposing Big 12 assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (2)

WR	7	Braden Pegan* (Jr.)	3	Nate Johnson (Sr.)
WR	12	Larry Simmons (Sr.)	6	Daidren Zipperer (Jr.)
WR	0	Kyri Shoels* (Sr.)	2	Creed Whittemore (Jr.)
LT	76	Zereoue Williams (Sr.)	72	Isaiah Garcia (So.)
LG	62	Solatoa Moea'i (Sr.)	55	Kelvin Obot (Fr.)
C	56	Isaiah Kema* (Fr.)	79	Alex Harrison (Sr.)
RG	74	Keith Olson (Sr.)	75	Roger Alderman (Jr.)
RT	73	Cedric Jefferson* (Jr.)	67	Soren Shinofield (So.)
TE	10	Hunter Andrews (So.)	89	Noah Bennee* (Sr.)
QB	4	DEVON DAMPIER (SR.)	15	Byrd Ficklin (So.)
RB	1	WAYSHAWN PARKER (JR.)	5	Daniel Bray (So.)

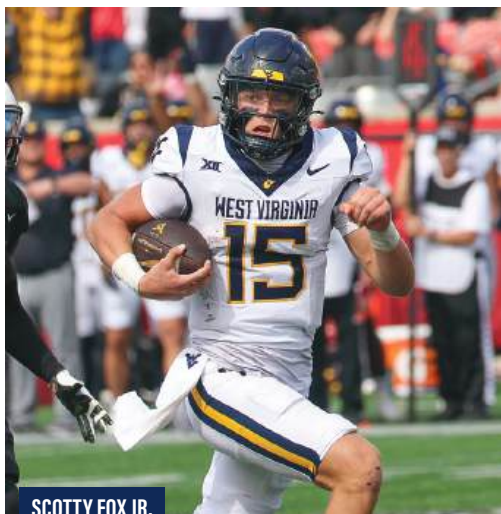
DEFENSE (3)

DE	15	Lance Holtzclaw (Sr.)	40	Paul Fitzgerald (Sr.)
DT	90	Jireh Moe* (So.)	45	Pupu Sepulona (So.)
DT	51	Karson Kaufusi (So.)	97	Lucas Samsula* (So.)
DE	93	Kash Dillon (So.)	8	Ethan Day* (Jr.)
LB	7	JOHNATHAN HALL (SR.)	83	Elijah Ellis (So.)
LB	0	Cyrus Polu (So.)	10	Trey Reynolds (Sr.)
CB	9	ELIJAH DAVIS (SR.)	4	JC Hart (Jr.)
CB	13	Elijah Reed* (Sr.)	19	James Chenault* (Jr.)
NB	11	Rock Caldwell (Sr.)	26	Nick Brown* (So.)
S	23	JACKSON BENNEE (JR.)	21	Nate Tilmon (So.)
S	1	Rabbit Evans (Sr.)	6	Nate Ritchie (Sr.)

SPECIALISTS

K	17	Dillon Curtis (So.)	KR	2	Creed Whittemore (Jr.)
P	92	Orion Phillips (Jr.)	PR	8	Mana Carvalho (So.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN BOLD • *2026 TRANSFER



SCOTTY FOX JR.

SCOUTING THE MOUNTAINEERS

"It's very similar to UCF. Once they get a triggerman, watch out for them. [Head coach] Rich Rodriguez wants to get the speed. Those offenses excel when he's got legit speed at quarterback, at running back and at receiver. I think he's solving that problem through the portal, with junior-college recruiting and with high school recruiting down in Florida. ... Once he gets the speed with the gun-run, and the quarterback plus-one in the run game, they'll have a chance. They didn't have that last year. We played them, and they didn't have any team speed. At least not what [Rodriguez] is used to having."

— An opposing Big 12 assistant coach

DEPTH CHART

OFFENSE (3)

WR	5	Jaden Bray (Sr.)	17	Prince Strachan* (Jr.)
WR	2	DJ Epps* (Sr.)	11	TaRon Francis* (Fr.)
WR	80	John Neider* (Jr.)	14	Keon Hutchins* (Jr.)
LT	79	Carsten Casady* (Jr.)	76	Deshawn Woods* (Sr.)
LG	52	NICK KRAHE (JR.)	67	LANDEN LIVINGSTON (SR.)
C	72	Cam Griffin* (Sr.)	78	Wes King* (Sr.)
RG	54	Amare Grayson* (Jr.)	69	Devin Vass* (Jr.)
RT	65	Malik Agbo (Sr.)	74	Kevin Brown (Fr.)
TE	84	Ryan Ward (Jr.)	0	Josh Sapp* (Sr.)
QB	3	Michael Hawkins Jr.* (So.)	15	SCOTTY FOX JR. (SO.)
RB	4	Cam Cook* (Sr.)	1	Amari Latimer (Fr.)

DEFENSE (0)

DE	96	Zeke Durham-Campbell* (Sr.)	91	Darius Wiley* (So.)
DT	72	Jaylen Thomas* (Jr.)	52	Corey McIntyre Jr. (Jr.)
DL	93	Nate Gabriel (Jr.)	43	KJ Henson* (Jr.)
EDGE	50	Harper Holloman* (Jr.)	99	David Afogho* (Jr.)
LB	15	Ben Cutter (Sr.)	45	Malachi Hood* (Sr.)
LB	34	Tyler Stolsky* (Sr.)	54	Isaiah Patterson* (So.)
CB	18	Chams Diagne* (Sr.)	19	Nick Taylor (Jr.)
CB	22	Jaire Rawlison* (So.)	4	Da'Mun Allen* (Jr.)
NB	1	Geimere Latimer II* (Sr.)	14	Andrew Powdrell* (Sr.)
S	8	Kamari Wilson* (Sr.)	3	Matt Sieg (Fr.)
S	29	Kameron Reddic* (Jr.)	6	Da'Mare Williams* (So.)

SPECIALISTS

K	42	Jack Cassidy* (Sr.)	KR	2	DJ Epps* (Sr.)
P	83	Bryan Hansen* (Sr.)	PR	2	DJ Epps* (Sr.)

RETURNING STARTERS IN **BOLD** • *2026 TRANSFER



WEST VIRGINIA MOUNTAINEERS

NATIONAL FORECAST: 50 | BIG 12 PREDICTION: 10 | 2025 RECORD: 4-8, 2-7 BIG 12

OFFENSE West Virginia returns the quarterback who finished the season last year in sophomore Scotty Fox Jr., but hand-picked Oklahoma transfer Michael Hawkins Jr. will provide competition and elevate the room. The Mountaineers were also able to land the leading rusher at the Division I level in Cam Cook from Jacksonville State, who piled up 1,659 yards and 16 touchdowns last season and will serve as a centerpiece in the run game.

The area most in need of improvement over last year is the offensive line. To that end, the Mountaineers brought back renowned position coach Rick Trickett. The line was a portal priority this offseason, adding five transfers with 91 combined starts to serve as the engine of the offense. The newcomers join returning starters Nick Krahe and Landen Livingston.

As long as the run game is more productive, the offense should be primed to take a major step forward with more consistency and a more versatile group of pass-catchers, nearly all of whom are transfers, including DJ Epps (Troy), John Neider (UConn), Prince Strachan (USC) and TaRon Francis (LSU).

DEFENSE Like his offensive colleagues, defensive coordinator Zac Alley will be adjusting to a lot of new faces across the various position rooms in his second season with the program, but there is reason for optimism given the personnel.

The Mountaineers were active in the transfer portal to address key needs as well as bringing in a talented top-20 recruiting class with several defensive standouts. The defense should be longer and more athletic while having more depth — especially on the edge and in the secondary — along with enough returning experience to yield a more productive group. Edge rusher Harper Holloman, a transfer from WKU who posted 5.5 tackles for a loss last season, could be a major disruptor, and Coastal Carolina transfer end Zeke Durham-Campbell looks to make a major impact as well.

SPECIALISTS The Mountaineers were aggressive in finding experienced specialists from the portal after losing both their punter and kicker from 2025. The coaches landed experienced punter Bryan Hansen and two kickers in Jack Cassidy and Peter Notaro who have played at the FBS level.

FINAL ANALYSIS For the second straight year, West Virginia welcomed more than 80 new players into the program, but with more time to evaluate and a bigger overall talent base, the program will be looking to take a significant step forward in Year 2 of head coach Rich Rodriguez's second stint in Morgantown. Given Rodriguez's track record, there's reason to believe that the Mountaineers should be able to do just that.

2025 RESULTS (4-8, 2-7 BIG 12)				2026 SCHEDULE		TOP 10 RECRUITS*	
Aug. 30	Robert Morris	W	45-3	Sept. 5	Coastal Carolina	1. Kevin Brown, IOL	★★★★
Sept. 6	at Ohio	L	10-17	Sept. 12	Tennessee-Martin	2. Amari Latimer, RB	★★★★
Sept. 13	Pitt (ot)	W	31-24	Sept. 19	vs. Virginia #	3. Vincent Smith, CB	★★★★
Sept. 20	at Kansas	L	10-41	Sept. 26	Oklahoma State	4. Jyron Hughley, QB	★★★★
Sept. 27	Utah	L	14-48	Oct. 3	at Iowa State	5. Chris Talley, RB	★★★★
Oct. 3	at BYU	L	24-38	Oct. 10	Arizona	6. Jonas Muya, OT	★★★★
Oct. 18	at UCF	L	13-45	Oct. 17	Cincinnati	7. Matt Sieg, S	★★★★
Oct. 25	TCU	L	17-23	Oct. 24	at TCU	8. Makhli Boone, CB	★★★★
Nov. 1	at Houston	W	45-35	Nov. 7	at Texas Tech	9. KJ Henson, DL	★★★★
Nov. 8	Colorado	W	29-22	Nov. 14	Kansas	10. Landon Drumm, WR	★★★★
Nov. 15	at Arizona State	L	23-25	Nov. 21	Houston		
Nov. 29	Texas Tech	L	0-49	Nov. 28	at Utah		
				#Charlotte, NC		*Per Rivals	

TEAM INFORMATION

Head Coach: Rich Rodriguez • Record at School: 64-34 (8 years) • Career Record: 194-137-2 (28 years) • Offensive Coordinator: Rich Rodriguez • Defensive Coordinator: Zac Alley • Location: Morgantown, W.Va. • Stadium: Mountaineer Field at Milan Puskar Stadium (60,000)